on worldbearing and other matters of divinity

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on worldbearing and other matters of divinity

by cloudhours

Summary

> Mydei pins him down with firm hands and says, low and urgent, “Listen—the people think you can bear a child.”
>
> Phainon blinks at him. Mydei waits for him to sputter, to laugh. To refute him and call the very notion ridiculous, and launch into an hours-long exposition on the sheer absurdity of such a statement.
>
> His husband does none of that.

(In the wake of Era Nova, peace settles—but gossip does not. Especially when it involves divine conception and the Deliverer of Amphoreus.)

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

It starts, as it often does, with the Trailblazers.

And it starts, as many things of this sort of nature often do, right in the middle of Marmoreal Market where anyone and everyone can hear them.

Chapter Notes

I can't believe that it was a gacha game that pulled me out of fandom retirement, and that my first offering to the myphaidei altar would be a what-if-pregnon story and *not* my enemies-to-friends-to-lovers canon divergence au.

But anyway, hello HSR fandom! English is not my first language and I joined in 3.0 so I'm still working my way through the lore. In the meantime, come partake with me in some married myphaidei trying to navigate misunderstandings about kephale's divine powers.

▶ **author's notes/content warnings**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It starts, as it often does, with the Trailblazers.

And it starts, as many things of this sort of nature often do, right in the middle of Marmoreal Market where anyone and everyone can hear them. Though, this detail won't hit Mydei until much later like the Astral Express careening into Amphoreus's sky and crashing a hair-length away from Okhema at the start of Era Nova.

Mydei is handing over payment for a jar of honey when he first hears it: Stelle's unmistakable voice carrying over the bustle of the market square.

"—reminds me of the whole classical antiquity metaphor, you know?"

Then Caelus, gentle and airy, with a note of panic: "I thought we weren't supposed to talk about it in public?"

"That was just Dan Heng's suggestion," Stelle says. "I didn't hear Cas and the others complaining when we were in the baths. I just think the potential makes it a little funny. Though, with all their lore and histories, doesn't it make you wonder?"

“No it doesn’t,” Caelus insists, “and keep your voice down, do you want us to get in trouble?”

Foreboding crawls down Mydei’s back. He nods to the vendor, who is craning his neck toward the source of the conversation, and strides across the square.

They’re standing near a fountain that overlooks the lower grounds, two baskets of produce at their feet. The morning crowd is giving the two a respectful berth, but more than a few people are glancing over their shoulders with curious looks. The twins’ backs are facing Mydei as he approaches, and he notes a pomegranate in Stelle’s hand.

Stelle scoffs. “Uh-huh, and who almost got into a fight with that scholar from Dolos because he didn’t agree with Dan Heng’s translation of the Kephale texts?”

Caelus rears up, suddenly unaware of how his voice starts to project. “That guy was misreading the secondary clause on purpose! It didn’t say ‘Kephale could carry within the seeds of creation,’ it said, ‘were the Sky Father to will it, creation would answer’. Dan Heng was right, there’s a difference in the implications!”

“What does the difference matter if there’s only so many books that even mention it?” Stelle waves the pomegranate. “Speaking of, why is that? You’d think more people would discuss it if it was so important.”

Caelus shrugs. “It’s like Cas said. The idea of *that* happening to Kephale was probably weird to some people.”

“How can it be weird? Wouldn’t it be part of the job description? They’re the Worldbearing Titan, aren’t they?”

Mydei says, “*Were* the Worldbearing Titan.”

Stelle jumps. The pomegranate goes flying. Caelus twists around so fast he topples to the cobblestones. Without missing a beat, Mydei catches the fruit in one hand and raises a brow as he regards them. “What was that about Kephale?”

“Mydei,” Stelle says, high-pitched, at the same time Caelus croaks, “Nothing!”

He crosses his arms—just so, the way Phainon once teased made his chest and shoulders bulge in a rather threatening manner. A small shame the basket of honey and fruit dangling on his wrist rather offsets the intimidation factor, but no matter. “I’ll ask again once and only once, what was that about Kephale and Worldbearing?”

Caelus, striking a faux-casual pose on the ground, laughs too quickly. “Nothing serious. Just some light theoretical discourse, right, Stelle?”

“Ye-*ep*,” Stelle pops the *p*, rocking back on her heels. “Just a friendly debate between curious minds, is all.”

“Mm.” Mydei turns the pomegranate over in his hand. “And this is the inspiration for said debate?”

Stelle glances at her twin, who frantically shakes his head. She gives a strained smile. “It’s mostly metaphor. Symbolism. Hypothetical stuff!”

“Caelus almost got into a fight over hypothetical stuff?”

Caelus’s next laugh edges on nervous. “You heard that part too?”

“I won’t be surprised if they heard you in the Grove,” Mydei says dryly. “So. What’s the metaphor?”

They stare at him wide-eyed. He tilts his head, challenging. “I am no stranger to scholarly debate. Maybe I can provide some insight.”

Stelle says consideringly, “Actually—”

“No,” Caelus hisses, then squeaks when Mydei glances at him, “I mean, it might be a little… Silly. And a bit ridiculous, to be honest. Probably not something worth bothering you with, Mydei.”

“A scholarly debate about Kephale isn’t worth my time?” Mydei drawls. “Have you forgotten who I’m married to? Stop beating around the bush. Tell me.”

Caelus makes a little choking sound. Stelle jumps in. “It’s more about *metaphorical* rebirth—seeds of potential, fruit of creation! That sort of stuff.”

Odd. These two are usually more forthcoming. Mydei’s jaw flexes as he tries for another angle. “Stuff that is *weird*, in your own words, to some people?”

“I personally don’t think it’s weird,” Stelle protests. “If anything, I think it’s mythologically consistent!”

“Consistent with what?” Mydei says, seizing the opening.

“Stelle,” Caelus says weakly.

“Well,” Stelle answers, voice crisp and clear in its non-discernment, “with whether or not Phainon can get pregnant.”

“I am sure,” Aglaea says in the most placid tone Mydei has ever heard, “that there is a *very* good reason why Mydeimos crystallized half of Marmoreal Market and blocked off all the central roads when we are still in the middle of rebuilding Okhema.”

In the past, she only ever called him Mydeimos when she was teetering on the precipice of patience, the visage of Garmentmaker hovering over her shoulder. On those rare occasions, Phainon also knelt in supplication beside him, but Mydei can’t even try to put half the blame on him this time.

Aglaea clears her throat.

He is not afraid, because Kremnoans fear nothing and he is Strife incarnate and the only equal to the Deliverer of Amphoreus—but he wisely keeps his eyes on the floor. At his sides, Caelus and Stelle shuffle awkwardly on their knees.

"Aglaea," Hyacine starts, ever the long-suffering witness and brave arbiter.

"No, no, let them explain themselves," Aglaea says sweetly. Gold threads weave into view around her hands.

"I will cover all expenses and make amends to the people," Mydei swears.

Aglaea says, unmoved, "I never doubted you would. I wish to know why such an act happened in the first place. My threads can no longer tell me such details, as you well know, so I must continue to pry like this. It is not like you to lose control, unless, ah."

She trails off. Hyacine giggles, covering her mouth.

Unless where Phainon is concerned, yes, Mydei knows. He has already accepted that long ago. Why else did he marry him?

"So it does have something to do with Phainon," Aglaea muses when he fails to reply, sounding thoughtful but not surprised. "Shall we fetch him, then? Surely he is awake at this time and can shed some light on this matter."

It certainly has something to do with Phainon.

Phainon, who is sleeping in, a rare luxury in all the years and cycles Mydei has known him. Sprawled across their kline, limbs tangled in the sheets and still bearing the marks of Mydei's mouth from last night. His braid loosely in place because he'd drifted off before Mydei could comb it out.

Phainon, curled on the left side of the bed—his side, because it's closest to the balcony that overlooks Okhema and catches the first blush of morning light. One hand curled over his belly, as he's been wont to do more often lately, like he's anchoring himself in the warmth of his own skin.

Phainon, still healing slowly, who deserves this quiet, unbothered morning. Who would, without question, stir at the first sign of a summons, bleary-eyed and dutiful, even if confused as to why it wasn't Mydei slipping into bed beside him to coax him awake as he's done every morning since the First Dawn.

Mydei blurts out, "The Trailblazer thinks Phainon can get pregnant."

Hyacine gasps. Aglaea freezes.

"He means Stelle," Caelus says immediately.

"You also think it!" the accused yelps, her voice echoing in the Hero's Bath. "You were the one who wanted to finish the whole translation of the book that Cas and the others found!"

“I wanted to finish it for Dan Heng’s data bank, but you kept bringing up the world-bearing translation. I didn’t even think about actual pregnancy until you mentioned it!”

The two are on their feet now, pointing at each other. Mydei warily leans away, not in the mood to get caught in the orbit of a stray flaming lance or baseball bat.

“But you don’t deny that you thought about it?”

“Who can’t think about it when you and Dan Heng and the others won’t stop talking about it?”

“Don’t you even start, I know you like it when Dan Heng talks—”

“Like you aren’t the same when Jing Yuan or Aventurine or Dr. Ratio—”

“Ohh now we’re listing names huh? Well a little birdie told me about seeing the fireworks on Penacony with—”

“Most distinguished heroes,” Aglaea says, just silken smooth enough to hide the threat underneath. “I believe that is a conversation best held elsewhere. Mydei, you may stop inching away and stand. The floor cannot be that comfortable.”

Mydei complies, willing his face to cool down. “Now you understand what I had to put up with earlier.”

“Indeed,” Aglaea says mildly. “I can imagine it was a great shock to hear if Phainon can bear children.”

“Because he can’t,” Mydei says. “It’s a ludicrous idea. Whatever the Trailblazers may have heard or read is simply folly. There is no precedent for such a thing. It’s impossible.”

Aglaea tilts her head. Her face is as unreadable as ever.

His throat tightens. For a reason he cannot name, tiny pinpricks run down his arms. Heat rises to the back of his neck, the palms of his hands.

“I told you so,” Stelle mutters, to which Caelus snaps, “Stop or we’re gonna get crystallized again. Look, he’s starting to glow.”

“Lord Mydei.” Hyacine approaches him with hands up as if soothing a startled dromas. “Please take some deep breaths. Kephale’s Worldbearing title has many translations and has been stylized in a number of different ways. Such an ability would certainly be noted somewhere in our histories. This is likely just a big misunderstanding.”

Mydei lets out a relieved breath. He can always count on Hyacine being a reliable voice of reason. But… “What do you mean by *likely*?”

The wide-eyed glance from Hyacine to Aglaea feels like a spear through his stomach.

“Likely,” he prompts when neither speaks up, the blood starting to rush again in his ears, “a grave mistranslation, or a jest made in poor taste by some immature scholar or acolyte, right? Kephale never got pregnant or bore children.”

Caelus raises his hand politely. “But didn’t They bring life to the first beings of Amphoreus? Isn’t that technically giving birth?”

“The origin stories of the past Titans are not meant to be taken that literally!”

Aglaea opens her mouth but Stelle pipes up instead, “Maybe there hasn’t been a chance for it to happen to Phainon?”

The brief icy silence that follows is damning.

“What,” Mydei says, low and rough, as Caelus tries to smother Stelle’s mouth, “does that mean?”

Stelle raises a brow, holding Caelus back with one hand on his face. “It’s been, what, a month since the start of Era Nova? Phainon’s only had his divinity for a few weeks max. What if, you know, there hasn’t been an *opportunity*?”

No opportunity? There are no words for how much Mydei wants to refute her statement.

There were three whole days after the First Dawn that he and Phainon were unaccounted for. Did she think they spent all that time holding hands and whispering tenderly to each other?

They did, eventually. But that was after they had lain together, again and again, beneath the swirling stars of the Vortex of Genesis until their divinities resonated so fiercely that a new constellation flared to life in the sky.

But there’s absolutely no world in which he’s saying that aloud.

Not with Hyacine of all people in attendance, her innocent face scrunched up like she’s trying to solve a math problem. Not with Aglaea, someone Phainon considers mother and mentor and dear friend, watching him like a bird of prey. Not to mention the blaring target he’ll paint on his back if this conversation gets back to Anaxa, who is currently researching the mysterious origin of said constellation.

Mydei counts to five and says, with deliberate calm, “Opportunity is not the factor we should be questioning.”

It is the plausibility—or rather, the irrefutable improbability—of child-bearing, should be obvious and goes unsaid. But Stelle, who is quickly destroying Mydei’s hopes for an amicable resolution to this fiasco, just shrugs.

“Maybe it is, since we don’t know how you two,” she makes a shameless hand gesture that makes them wince. “Or vice versa? I don’t know if Phainon can handle that yet. Or maybe I’m wrong and you guys are doing a dry run, but knowing you and him…”

The air gets heavier, sewn tight by the sharp sensation of lightning, of an incoming storm. Caelus has gone pale. Mydei resists the urge to wipe the sudden sweat on his forehead. *Strife*. Aglaea is going to kill him, then Anaxa will arrive from the Grove and patiently stand over his limp body until he revives before stringing him up and using him for target practice. He will never be able to look Hyacine in the eye again after this.

Aglaea, decidedly not killing him yet, says, "Go on, Mydei. We are all adults here."

That is up for debate, he thinks as Stelle and Caelus shout-whisper to each other while gesturing at him, but seizes the lifeline that the Goldweaver deigned to throw to him.

"Not that it is anyone's business," he says, every drop of decorum in him balking at publicly insinuating at his and Phainon's bedroom affairs, "but there have been plenty of chances. Abundantly so."

"That's not what I meant," Aglaea says wearily at the same time Caelus says, "Now that's a thought—Path of Abundance," he adds when they stare at him.

"Ahh," only Stelle says after a long moment, nodding sagely.

Another pause. There is the gentle sloshing of the baths. Below them, the distant sounds of people going about their day.

Phainon will be waking soon. Mydei realizes, belatedly, that he hasn't even started breakfast yet. There's no doubt that Phainon will say he doesn't mind, that Mydei doesn't need to go through all that effort every morning. He'll brush it off with a smile and suggest they eat instead at one of the many stalls outside, calling it his treat as if they do not share the same purse for everything.

But he knows Phainon likes to break fast in their room, just the two of them, a moment in each other's company before duty calls. The balcony window opened wide to let in the sunlight and fresh air. Their private bath drawn just below cool, with tiny glass bottles of fragrance oils resting on two folded towels.

The food would be arranged bathside: Mydei had been planning to make a platter piled high with tagēnitēs drizzled in rich honey; a jug of pomegranate juice and a goblet half-filled with fresh goat milk; bunches of bright purple grapes nestled next to thick slices of bread spread with savory olive relish, Phainon's favorite to eat and Mydei's least favorite to feed him because of the crumbs, but he does anyway.

At some point, the rising sun would slip into the room and drape Phainon's bare skin like fine gold silk. Bold like a lover's embrace—the sheer nerve of it.

Mydei couldn't fault it. Not when he understood the feeling so very well. Still, he'd make his claim known, pulling Phainon into his lap mid-ramble and kissing him thoroughly. The dazed, incredulous look Phainon always gave him after was a victory in itself, one he never tired of earning.

Longing unfurls. Curls up tight in his chest, around every rib.

He tells Stelle, resolute, “To answer your question from before, no. I don’t think Phainon can get pregnant, whether because of Kephale’s divinity or by any other way.”

I would know, he thinks. *If it were possible, I would be the first to know*.

Caelus gives him a complicated look. Stelle tilts her head. He wonders if he can see a glimmer of the Stellaron in her eyes when she smiles and says, “Okay, Mydei.”

“You shut down the markets?” is the first thing Phainon says when Mydei bursts into their room with a tray in hand.

“Why do you assume me to be the instigator,” Mydei grumbles before the words catch and dry up in his throat.

Phainon is reclining on their kline with nothing but a thin sheet covering his lower half. One hand holds his teleslate, the other rests low on his abdomen. A breeze through the open balcony window tousles his hair, lifting the loose ends of his braid. His neck is bare.

The front door had been left slightly ajar, as if Phainon had been anticipating his arrival. Mydei thinks, not for the first time, that it was an excellent idea to claim the private wing in the Heirs’ apartments.

There is no risk of some oblivious passerby or Chrysos Heir wandering the halls outside to accidentally witness Phainon like this. The man is shameless enough to pad around their rooms without a chiton, without his underclothes, without *anything* sometimes. The audacity. Mydei has no desire to share even a glimpse of him in this state with others.

Mydei exhales when he feels the tray beginning to bow under the grip of his fingers, and releases the metal carefully.

“Caelus and Stelle can’t summon red crystals, can they?” Phainon points out, waving the teleslate at him, oblivious to how the motion makes the sheet slide down. *Strife and calamity*. The fine taper of his waist is ludicrous, but the curves of his hips and thighs frankly need their own warning signs.

Not that anyone but Mydei will ever see them, feel their warmth under their teeth, know the way they shake and yield under both gaze and touch.

He made sure of that when he finally took Phainon to hearth and husband.

“Mydei.”

“Yes.” Followed by, “What, again?”

Phainon snorts and puts away the teleslate, tugging up the sheet for a more respectable coverage. “Come here, you. What are you standing there for?”

He drags his eyes up to meet Phainon’s grin. “I have to go back to Marmoreal Market in a quint.”

“I know, Hyacine gave me a heads-up.” He winks. “I negotiated with Aglaea for three quints. You’re welcome.”

Negotiated, he says. As if Aglaea would be able to say no to those big blue eyes after everything that has happened.

The extra time is a blessing, nonetheless. He secures the tray by the bath, shucks his robes and gauntlets, and slides into Phainon’s waiting arms. The kline creaks but holds as they shift to curl around each other. The sheet stays bunched up between them as he settles on top of Phainon with a low sigh.

“My, that sounds heavy for this early in the morning.” Steady fingers card through his hair, pulling gently at the roots. The intimacy of it, hard-won and long awaited for, makes him bury his face in Phainon’s neck and breathe deeply.

Sun-dried linen and labdanum, with a hint of olive resin, and fire. The scent sinks familiar and heady into his bones. If the divine power inside him were a lion, it would be purring loud enough to shake the walls, content in the presence of its mate.

“Not so early anymore,” he says, nosing along the divots of Phainon’s collarbones where his smell is strongest. “It’s almost Ascent Hour. What have you been doing all this time?”

“I fed the chimeras and read the news. Imagine my surprise when I saw your face plastered all over the front page.” A playful tug at the end of his braid. “I also got the strangest message from the *trapeza* letting me know that we have a hundred thousand balance coins credited to our account. Tell me, are we paying that in full or in installments?”

Mydei groans. They had to spend thrice that for their official wedding, but it is still no small amount. Aglaea truly never goes back on her word, or the words of others. When he gets his hands on the Trailblazers, he’s going to shake them for all they’re worth, their many admirers across the Cosmos be damned. He can take on all of them.

“Charge half of that to Stelle and Caelus,” he says. “Don’t let them leave Okhema until they pay up. With how much they hoard, it shouldn’t be an issue.”

Phainon laughs, his broad chest shaking under Mydei’s cheek. “You’ll have better luck getting the money from the Verax Leos. Caelus already went back up to the Astral Express. Stelle is on her way to the Grove.”

“Aglaea sent her?”

“No, apparently there’s a project she’s been working on for a while with Professor Anaxa.”

Mydei begrudgingly admires the twins’ frightening efficacy in finding the best ways to avoid him. He and the rest of the Chrysos Heirs have an open invitation to visit the Astral Express anytime, but Caelus would definitely hide in Dan Heng’s room, which is a line Mydei refuses to cross.

Likewise, he has no desire to deal with Anaxa's thinly veiled half-threats about treating Phainon carefully, what with the state of his body after ushering in Era Nova.

He can't quite wrap his head around it. The man approved their union then acts as if Mydei has turned into a different beast who ravishes Phainon on the daily. He has it on record that he is the more careful one—their three days of reunion aside.

Warm lips brush his forehead, effectively diverting his thoughts. "So, mind telling me what was so serious that warranted everyone in Okhema getting a public service announcement?"

The pomegranate in Stelle's hand appears in his mind. An inexplicable tension starts in his lower back, shot through with something he cannot name. It feels like the shape of the word *want*.

He shakes his head of the thought and tightens his arms around Phainon. "Nothing. The Trailblazers just caught me off-guard."

"Those are two different statements," Phainon says lightly. "You haven't lost control of your *thymós* like that in a while. Did they challenge you to another one of their speed-running contests again?"

His nails, trimmed short, scratch up and down Mydei's back. Mydei arches into the touch, letting it soothe him. "All they challenged was my patience. Don't worry about it. You should focus on yourself first."

"You're deflecting," Phainon whines. "I'm not going to break apart. It doesn't look like it much, but I am getting better. Give me your hands."

He does. Phainon guides them down his chest and flanks, around his back, over the worst of his fracture lines.

Rhimágmata, is what Anaxa and that Herta woman decided to name them—the deep and wide scars lacing Phainon's body, filled with starlit divinity like aureate ichor and sealed over by embroideries of translucent threads.

Marks of Destruction that will never fully heal or fade. Phainon will carry the ache of each discontinuity for the rest of his life. It is the price he pays for the Miracle of Genesis, for the backlash that Era Nova wrought on the Cosmos.

Mydei maps every inch offered to him and can only feel a quiet, deep reverence.

"I think this one is getting smaller," Phainon is saying, brushing the edge of a particularly long cicatrix that cuts through his hip. "The ones on my face are also better compared to last week."

Mydei goes there next with curious fingertips—over Phainon's clavicle and the mark of the sun, inlaid with shimmering gold of divinity; up the slope of that deceptively strong jawline, which he nips and is rewarded with a laugh; then, then to the soft curves of Phainon's cheeks, heating up beneath his touch and scrunching up as Mydei cups them for a better look.

The harsh *rhimágmata* that once ran jagged across his face have closed into thin glimmering lines, like veins in crystal. Mydei skims over them, noting with no small amount of pride at how quickly Phainon relaxes into his hands. “How much do they hurt?”

“They don’t—” Phainon says, quelling when Mydei looks at him with a raised brow—“hurt as much as before.” He nudges his chin against Mydei’s palm with a disarming grin. “Not since I had this very handsome man taking care of me, cooking me the best meals, giving me the most tender loving care.” Waggles his eyebrows. “Do you think he’ll let me return the favor when I get better?”

“… You are the most embarrassing *HKS* I have ever met,” Mydei says. “Get away from me.”

“You're the one still holding me,” Phainon sing-songs. “So, as you can see, I am doing just fine. Well enough to help you with the clean-up later.”

Mydei frowns, releasing Phainon’s face and pushing himself up on his elbows to properly look at him. “I can handle it by myself. You’re supposed to have another session with Hyacine. You needn’t trouble yourself with my consequences… what?”

Phainon is smiling at him, momentarily quiet. His cheeks are flushed a light attractive pink, the mark of the sun on his neck and chest glowing. Fingers dance up Mydei’s forearms, his shoulders, over thick cords of muscle until they come to rest on his nape. He says, matter of fact, “It’s exactly because they’re your consequences that I trouble myself with them. Your fight is my fight, remember?”

The words of their vows, vivid and grounding. Sudden shivers burst and spread over Mydei’s skin, racing through his nerves. His tattoos begin to emit telltale scarlet light, his *thymós* stoked by proximity and promise. “Cleaning up smashed vegetables and rubble is hardly a worthy fight.”

“Still, you’ve chosen to take it on,” Phainon says. A mischievous glint enters his eyes. “What, think I’ll do a better job than you? Tell you what, I’ll stay in bed to give you a head start. I won’t even get dressed yet—though, knowing you, I’d wager that might have the opposite effect.”

“You,” Mydei declares, trying to sound more incensed than he feels as he leans down, “will need that head start more than me.”

Phainon is laughing when he meets Mydei in the middle. It's a brush of the lips more than a kiss, brief and sweet. A peck, Phainon likes to call it. A childish word, but it makes him smile when Mydei says it, so it’s acceptable.

One more peck, then twice again, before Phainon sighs, tilting his head to better the angle. Several languid moments pass like deep sips of honey brew. The sunlight on Mydei’s back. Phainon’s arms winding around his neck. Their legs sliding, trying to instinctively move into familiar positions, barred only by thin fabric.

It is still novel, this exchange of lips and breaths and hands sliding under cloth to caress bare skin, over scars new and old. Before, there had been moments somewhat similar to this, but

brief. Uncertain. Dancing the blurry lines between competitor and companion, friend and lover. Those moments were as fleeting as time for rest, stolen between endless battles that wearied the heart and body.

It is better, now.

Phainon lightly bites Mydei's lower lip, followed by licking into his mouth in a long, sensuous stroke. Mydei grunts, pleased. A familiar heat simmers to life under his skin.

Another lick, sliding over his tongue. His hips buck down before he can stop them. A sudden push, and he's flipped on his back as Phainon plants himself on top. Arousal thrums low, makes his toes curl hard. This is one of their favorite ways, among many. Perhaps because it is so reminiscent of their first time.

"You're going to make me late," he rasps, not ashamed to admit he's already straining against his pants, pleased to feel Phainon's own desire hot against him. They start to rock together, inevitable. One hand finds its way to Phainon's hip; the other to his neck, urging him down so Mydei can take his mouth again.

"We don't have to take long," Phainon gasps when he breaks away, lips wet and red-bitten, well-kissed. He steadies himself over Mydei's chest, squeezing lightly. His braid falls from behind his ear to dangle between them. At the end, a golden clasp gleams.

("I will take you as you are," Phainon vowed, voice rising with the light of a new world, smiling as Mydei sealed the clasp, "and give you me, as I am—")

Mydei takes the end of Phainon's braid and brings it to his lips. "I would take my time with you," he says, "*husband.*"

The sheet slips away. Phainon's eyes are so very blue, shining with joy. Daylight crowns him in a resplendent veil.

Let the world wait, Mydei thinks. It will not collapse in their absence. *Let us have this just a little longer*.

"It's a good thing," Phainon says breathlessly, boldly, as he settles on Mydei's lap like a royal consort on his rightful throne, "that we have three quints, don't we?"

It is the middle of Parting Hour by the time Mydei heaves the last of the rubble onto the cart. The citizens move around the cordoned off area, giving him sympathetic smiles. They must have read the second public service announcement, the one that specifically outlined his mistake from this morning and the promise he made to Aglaea.

Breathing heavily, he lifts a hand to acknowledge them. Some well-meaning civilians come close, looking eager to help, but he waves them off like he did all the others.

Aglaea had made it very clear he was to finish this part of the markets on his own. Not that he was planning to do otherwise, his current bet with Phainon in place or not.

Demetria is waiting with a basket when Mydei approaches her. She smiles and dips her head. “Finished, Lord Mydei? That was quite fast. I have yet to receive word on Lord Phainon’s progress in the north district.”

“No need,” he says, trying to keep his tone level and not as smug as he feels. “I shall go see him myself, and collect my prize in person.”

It looks like he has come out triumphant, as expected. Phainon may be recovering well enough, but his strength and stamina are nowhere near what they were before. Hauling heavy marble and stone must not come with the same ease he enjoyed when he was able to yank Aquila out of the sky.

Perhaps their earlier indulgence hadn’t done Phainon any favors either. Like with all their intimate encounters, Mydei had made certain to leave his husband boneless and undone more than once. The time limit had not been an issue. If anything, it only spurred him to make the most of it. When Phainon was able to crawl out of bed was hard to say.

“Oh my,” Demetria giggles. She covers her mouth, but her eyes twinkle with a knowing mirth. “The stakes must be quite high for you to smile like that, my lord.”

He firmly schools his expression, but Demetria only laughs and shakes her head like a scolding grandmother. She pushes the basket into Mydei’s hands. “Take these as a token of my thanks. No, no, you must accept them. The honeydew and herbs are fresh from today’s stock, and I’m sure you will find a use for the fig syrup.”

Mydei’s eyes widen at the weight of the basket. It is not uncommon for Chrysos Heirs to receive gifts or trinkets from the public. Demetria herself long had the habit of piling fruits into his and Phainon’s arms whenever they visited her stall. But what she has given him can supply days’ worth of meals, and some of the plants are ones he has never received before nor used in his cooking.

His confusion must break through his steel face because Demetria clicks her tongue. She points to each one as she lectures sternly, “That one is moonmender root, good for returning vitality to the blood. This is cremni pear—boil it with apple peel and you’ll have a tonic that helps minimize muscle cramps. Ray fennel is bitter if eaten raw but you won’t find a better plant for sleeplessness. As for Phoros pollen, I would add it to a mild soup or tea for a boost of energy during the day. For Lord Phainon, I recommend a pinch or two. No more, or he won’t be able to rest comfortably at night.”

His head is spinning. Hyacine would have loved this kind of conversation, but it’s all Mydei can do to keep up. “I see. Thank you, Demetria.”

Her smile turns wistful. “Things must be difficult on Lord Phainon’s body. It hasn’t been much time at all since the First Dawn. I can’t imagine he’s not aching in some way, in his state. You’ll see to his comfort in the coming months, won’t you?”

“Of course,” he replies without hesitation, because it is the truth. “I will be at his side, always.” It warms him to know that Demetria, a trusted and reliable figure among the people,

continues to think about Phainon's well-being. He is not alone in his regard for their Deliverer even after the start of Era Nova.

Demetria instantly looks misty-eyed. She pats his arm and shoos him away. "Go on, now. Find your husband and get him started on those herbs. I expect an update when you stop by next time!"

Mydei bids her farewell and heads toward the northern side of the markets, the area Phainon claimed for himself in their little competition. Along the way, citizens pass him in clusters. Some are heading home, others rushing to the baths or diners. More than a few whisper to each other as he walks past, looking excited.

Perhaps there is a new event elsewhere in the city, or some fresh batch of gossip has made its rounds among the youth. Mydei chooses not to dwell on it. He's dirty, sore, and hungry after hours of labor. The sooner he and Phainon can bathe and have dinner, the sooner they can bed down for the night.

He quickens his pace. It doesn't take long to find Phainon under an awning of a fabrics stall, a half-full cart of rubble nearby. Mydei halts mid-step. Ice-cold sensation runs down his back.

Phainon is seated awkwardly on a bench, shoulders hunched, his hands moving over his knees. A small crowd of people hovers around him. Although he masks it well, Mydei can see it clearly: his husband's face is tight with pain.

A blinding flash of scarlet. Mydei is at his side before he registers moving. The crowd parts with a collective exclamation as he drops the basket.

"What happened?" he asks sharply, kneeling and reaching for Phainon. "Are you hurt? Let me see."

"Just a muscle strain, is all." Phainon offers a small smile. He sounds exhausted, the vigor from this morning dimmed. Mydei knows from experience that were he to check under Phainon's tunic, his *rhimágmata* would be glowing a painful, angry red.

"I'm fine already," Phainon continues. "No need to look so fretful. I heard you already finished your side. Seems like I'm on the losing end today, eh? Want to have another go? I think the east side of the market is still unfinished."

Mydei bats away Phainon's hands, replacing it with his own. The muscles and tendons beneath are warm and slightly swollen. He squeezes just a bit, testing.

Phainon flinches with a hiss.

Mydei lets go and sends a message on his teleslate, scanning the almost immediate response. "Congratulations *HKS*, you've won yourself another round of bed rest. Come, we're going to Hyacine."

"Have you picked up a new habit of overreacting? I've had wounds much more grievous than this little sprain. Give me a few minutes and I'll be right as—Mydeimos!" Phainon shrieks

with newfound energy as Mydei scoops him up with ease, adjusting him before grabbing the basket too. “You *will* put me down!”

“Stop squirming and this will go by faster,” Mydei says, nodding to the now silent, wide-eyed crowd as he strides past them toward Marmoreal Palace. “How can you expect your condition to get any better if you keep overextending yourself?”

“I didn’t realize pulling a few muscles counts as overextending,” Phainon snarks, wrapping his arms around Mydei in a way that suggests he’s one jostle away from turning them into a noose around Mydei’s neck. “Or justification to be hauled about like a sack of potatoes.”

“The sack would be better behaved,” Mydei mutters, which earns him a sudden indignant bite on the cheek. “You! What are you, a human or an animal?”

“Technically, I’m a demigod like you, so—”

They stay like that all the way up to Marmoreal Palace. For the whole duration of Hyacine’s exasperated examination and lecture to get some rest. All throughout dinner as Mydei stands sentinel while Phainon grumpily drinks all of the cremni pear tonic, and a quick bath, until Mydei dumps his freshly-toweled infuriating hyena of a husband into their kline, minding the two chimeras already curled around each other at the foot of the bed. He clambers in beside him, slotting himself along Phainon’s back and listening to him ramble sleepily.

“—and so, in a metaphorical yet not necessarily but also not excluding metaphysical sense, you and I and everyone else could be considered both human and animal.”

“You’re delirious and have no idea what you’re saying.” Mydei slides his hands around Phainon’s waist and up the lines of his chest, appreciating the subtle flex of muscles. He finds the pulse of Phainon’s heartbeat, steady and sure under his palms.

“That’s Kremnoan for, your words are too big for my brain but you’re absolutely right, as you always are, Phainon, my love, my dear,” Phainon tries to mimic Mydei’s voice. It comes out slurred and lazy, tired, nothing like him at all.

Affection crests inside Mydei like a tide. “That is an awful imitation,” he says, the criticism far too dampened to be taken seriously. “If I didn't know any better, I’d have thought you were doing it on purpose. Are you trying to insult me?”

“I’d like to see you,” Phainon yawns, “try to do better.” His hands cover Mydei’s, heavy and grounding, thumbs gliding along vein and tattoo. The modesty of the gesture does not rob it of its intimacy. “Bet you… can’t.”

Mydei buries his face into the warm slope of Phainon’s neck, the curve of his smile hidden but close enough for Phainon to feel its shape, and know it’s just for him. “Mark your words. We shall see who is victorious in the morning.”

Night wraps around them, soft and unintrusive. Mydei has left their balcony window open, the distant sounds of the Holy City long quieted in welcomed repose. Outside, the wind rustles, and moonlight spills across the floor in silver streams.

Mydei is nearly asleep when Phainon stirs and speaks, barely audible and slowly, as if revealing a painful secret. “Mydei… I don’t want to go on bed rest again. It’s more painful to just lie here and do nothing. I want to be outside—” He cuts off, and says no more.

There was a time when Phainon would never have admitted such a thing, would have let it build up and fester inside him until the inevitable end of a cycle when it shattered along with the rest of the world, to be left as a ghost in a forgotten past.

Mydei endures the ache that steals through him and presses a long kiss to the mark of the sun, which flickers faintly. A soft red glow like candlelight bathes the kline as his *thymós* sleepily responds to its partner’s vulnerability.

“Then rest well tonight, so you have enough energy to keep up with us tomorrow.”

“What are we doing tomorrow?” Phainon’s voice is worn, on the edge of sleep, but also threaded with unspoken tension. It is like this most nights. They are learning to work through it.

“Anything,” Mydei promises. “We can do anything.”

He speaks of visiting the dromases with Castorice, or a long overdue visit to the hometown of the Holy Maidens of Janusopolis. A day trip to Akashic ahead of their annual Georios ritual, with potential for an overnight stay. Perhaps, if Phainon wants and Mydei has enough time to brace himself, the Grove to see Anaxa and meet the newest batch of scholars; the latter option would at least give Mydei a chance to chase down Stelle and demand recompense while Phainon kept Anaxa busy.

Somewhere in the middle, Phainon turns over. His hands find the strong line of Mydei’s spine, counting each vertebrae with practiced ease. They stop where he alone is permitted to touch, shielding, reverent.

Mydei continues to murmur in his ear, and the tension in Phainon soon slackens. Within heartbeats, his breathing deepens and steadies into a peaceful rhythm that Mydei knows only comes when he feels truly safe.

He follows his husband not long after, content.

And so Amphoreus turns, flipping the page of the world to a new day, the stars tilting on their axis. When dawn breaks over the horizon, it carries a message on the wind: a whisper sparked by those witness to circumstance, kindling fast, taking shape in the minds and mouths of many. Interpretations multiply, meanings diverge, yet one truth rises above all—

The heir, it proclaims, *the heir is on its way*.

Chapter End Notes

I made a twt just to save and share hsr content, but I'd love to follow other myphai/phaidei folks!

Many of my personal headcanons have made their way into this story, some of which will be expanded on later, though most of them are honestly self-indulgent.

Edit (07/06/2025): I forgot to include some details and edits I had in my final draft before transferring to Ao3. The chapter has been updated!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> Mydei rests his head against Phainon’s shoulder and closes his eyes. He lets the sound of Phainon's voice wash over him. Wills the knot of heat and tension in his body to unravel quietly.
>
> Moments like these are precious. He won’t let them be spoiled by…. Foolish inklings. Foolish thoughts of foolish things.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you so much for all the comments and kudos! I apologize for the late update, I finally graduated and took a long-awaited vacation. I hope the extra long chapter makes up for it!
>
> No beta, and all of this was edited on mobile, so please forgive if there are any mistakes or formatting errors ヽ(ｏ＞ ∪ ＜)ノ
>
> ▶ **author’s notes/content warnings**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei wakes to the lingering impression of Phainon beside him. He blinks in the dim light and reaches out, brushing over the still-warm divots in the sheets. The absence takes a moment to register, his thoughts sluggish and slow to form. He’s used to waking with Phainon in his arms or tucked up around his back. The lack of his familiar weight is disconcerting.

He sits up. Outside, the morning draws a faint outline of Okhema’s skyline. It’s earlier than when they usually rise. The absence of the Dawn Device is still a significant adjustment.

He rubs the sleep out of his eyes, focuses and—there. His husband sits at the foot of the bed with various scrolls spread around him, illuminated by a lit bronze lamp on a nearby low table. He’s wearing a short chiton that must be one of Mydei’s, hemmed in red and black. Beagle Coconut is curled up in a fluffy ball on his lap while Honey Fruitcake nestles into his side, his upper body draped across Phainon’s leg and nose buried in Beagle Coconut’s fur.

Phainon reaches for a scroll. A few strands of hair fall into his eyes. He absently tucks them behind his ear. The lamplight pools in his collarbones, spills across his skin in soft amber,

catching on each *rhimágmata* and every little scar, even the tips of the divots along his back where his wings would emerge if ever called.

Mydei's fingers itch for his teleslate, or even a brush. He's no talent for painting, but perhaps he can learn. For moments like these. They have time now, after all. Time for art and reading and slow mornings. Time to create what the world no longer demands they destroy.

He shifts, familiar with but still unprepared for how full his chest suddenly feels. Phainon looks over his shoulder. His eyes wrinkle with a smile. "Hi, good morning. I was trying to be quiet. Did I wake you?"

"You didn't," Mydei says gruffly. He stays where he is, resisting the urge to reach over and gather Phainon into his arms, if only to not disturb his reading. "You're up already." It's a half-question.

Phainon shrugs, looking sheepish. "I felt too awake, for some reason." He pats the space next to him. "Sit and read with me?"

Mydei is already slipping out from under the sheet. He carefully avoids the sleeping chimeras and settles beside his husband. If Beagle Coconut hadn't taken his place on Phainon's lap, he would have gladly laid his head there and let Phainon run his hands through his hair.

"Are you feeling unwell?" he asks, encircling Phainon's bare knee with a gentle hand. "Do your legs still hurt?"

"Would you believe me if I say I feel better than ever?" Phainon replies. "That tonic you gave me worked wonders. I feel like I have enough energy to run a hundred laps around Okhema."

"We'll have to thank Demetria for the recipe," Mydei says. "She gave us other ones to try. I'll experiment with our breakfast today, if you can find it in yourself to not be so disappointed at the lack of olive relish."

"You know I'll never turn down anything you make." The corners of Phainon's lips lift. "Experiment or not. After all, was it not I who insisted on having the first taste of your—what did the twins call it—crystal lizard satay?"

Heat creeps up Mydei's neck. That dish was a recipe Caelus and Stelle taught him from Jarilo-VI. They promised it would be a great pre-spar snack, going so far as to procure the main ingredients for him. After eating one, Phainon had landed in bed with a fever for several quints while Mydei sweated and swore over the worst stomach ache he had since his time in the wilds.

The blistering chase he gave the twins through Okhema once the pain became tolerable was lauded as one of the greatest displays of endurance and dexterity the citizens had seen. It has its own mural in the Court of Seasons.

"That," he growls, "won't happen again."

Phainon rubs his back. “I doubt Demetria would give us anything like that. Actually,” he draws one of the scrolls closer, scanning it thoughtfully. “Everthing she gave us seem to have multiple uses, all good.”

“How so?” Mydei asks, getting comfortable for one of Phainon’s long winding explanations.

Phainon hums. “Did you know that in Oleinus, they brewed cremni pear and apple peel together into a tonic for expectant mothers? Helped ease muscle cramps in their first and second trimesters.”

Mydei chokes, tensing. Phainon startles and thumps on his back. “What,” Mydei croaks, willing his *thymós* to be calm, please, not a crystallization mishap in their private rooms of all places. “Expectant—expectant mothers?”

Phainon nods earnestly. “It was a tradition for pregnant women to drink one cup every day to relieve muscle aches. But its effects became so well regarded that even the soldiers of Oleinus and its neighboring city-states started using it for recovery after battles. Mydei, are you okay? Your face is pale.”

General use for muscle aches. It makes sense. Perfect, logical sense. There were many herbs and plants back in Kremnos used for all manner of things, pregnancy included, but nothing unusual about that, right?

Mydei takes a deep, steadying breath to collect his thoughts. “Fine, I’m fine. That’s interesting. I didn’t expect the tonic to have a maternal origin.”

Phainon chuckles. “I was caught off-guard as well. When I first read it, I thought,” he pauses. Something flickers in his eyes before it disappears under a bright smile. “I mean, I’m glad I was able to try it. It was delicious.”

Mydei swallows hard past the sudden lump in his throat. There it is again—the feeling at the base of his spine. “I’m glad. I… what else were you reading?”

He was never good at subtly changing the subject, but Phainon doesn’t seem to mind, relaxing into his side. He watches, throat still tight, as his husband rifles through the scrolls.

“There is this one book that Dan Heng gave me a few days ago. He mentioned it’s a copy of some academic texts from his homeland. His people are called the Vidyadhara. Apparently, they’re a long-life species who hatch from eggs after hundreds of years of molting…”

Mydei rests his head against Phainon’s shoulder and closes his eyes. He lets the sound of Phainon's voice wash over him. Wills the knot of heat and tension in his body to unravel quietly.

Moments like these are precious. He won’t let them be spoiled by…. Foolish inklings. Foolish thoughts of foolish things. So he sinks into the stories Phainon shares with him, of dragons and rebirth and mythical glowing eggs, and lets Phainon’s words carry him elsewhere.

They stay like that until dawn blooms over Okhema, oranges and yellows blending into the brightening blue. Phainon douses the lamp. Their room warms as the early breeze ruffles the scrolls and sheets. The chimeras stir awake.

Mydei watches through half-lidded eyes as Honey Fruitcake croons to Beagle Coconut, pawing at his flank. But instead of leaping on his mate in glee like he usually does in the morning, Beagle Coconut whines and firmly burrows his head into Phainon's stomach.

Phainon makes a startled sound. "Hey now little one, what's the matter?" The chimera squeaks in protest when he tries to lift him. "Huh. Someone's clingy today."

Honey Fruitcake chirrups loudly, trying to worm his way onto Phainon's lap. Mydei can hear his worry but, "Behave," he says and picks him up. One chimera is heavy enough, and Honey Fruitcake has particularly sharp claws. "Let him be. He'll come to you when he's ready. And you," he tells Beagle Coconut, "watch where you're putting those horns."

Beagle Coconut's responding apologetic croon is muffled by Phainon's chiton. Honey Fruitcake, on the other hand, narrows his eyes and growls at Mydei as if personally insulted. Mydei stares him back down, unimpressed.

"He's not going to gorge me," Phainon chides. He runs his hands over Beagle Coconut, looking thoughtful. "Is it just me or is he getting rounder?"

Honey Fruitcake squeals, squirming so wildly that Mydei has to place him on the ground. "I wouldn't be surprised, with how many snacks you give him when you think I'm not looking."

"You know about that?" Phainon exclaims, clutching Beagle Coconut who also squeaks incredulously.

Mydei rolls his eyes. Phainon didn't even try to deny it. "I know about it because I'm the one who makes those snacks for you in the first place."

Phainon winces. "Looks like we've been found out, little one," he says to Beagle Coconut, who lifts his head from Phainon's belly with a curious awoo. Phainon scratches him under his chin. "Ready to face the day? Your partner's waiting for you."

Honey Fruitcake nearly shakes with impatience as Phainon gently sets a now docile Beagle Coconut on the floor. The moment his paws touch down, Honey Fruitcake tussles him to the ground and begins grooming him with rough and scolding sounds. Beagle Coconut bats him away, barking, and there they go, rolling around and nipping playfully at each other.

Mydei thinks, now that is an excellent idea, and turns to his husband. Phainon is smiling, watching the chimeras play-fight. Then their eyes lock, and he flushes in unmistakable understanding.

"Mydei," he says, scrambling further up the kline. Then, louder but no less delighted as Mydei advances, "*Mydeimos*, the chimeras—"

“Already have a head start,” Mydei says gravely, and tackles him into the sheets. After, when he’s aching in the best way and luxuriating in how Phainon gazes down at him in pleasure and happiness, Mydei pulls him down and murmurs against his lips, “Phainon, good morning.”

Much later, their teleslates buzz in unison, breaking the peaceful quiet. Phainon’s teleslate rattles so much it falls off the kline.

“Did we miss something?” Phainon muses, pausing in his washing of Mydei’s hair.

Mydei, lazy and pliant under Phainon’s hands, frowns at the interruption. He reaches for his own teleslate and sighs at the numerous group chats waiting to be opened.

Phainon leans over his shoulder, his chest damp and warm. “Not good news?”

“We’ll see.” Mydei opens the messages and tilts the teleslate so Phainon can read at the same time.

Aglaea
See you at the baths

> The Station wants to meet with Phainon and Tribios. I’ve attached a copy of their official request for your purview. I was able to negotiate the duration to a day only. Do keep a handle on that *thymós* of yours in the meantime.

Welt Yang
Everyone on the Express, please constantly keep in touch.

> Good morning, Mydeimos. Lady Aglaea might have already told you about the situation. It’s ahead of schedule, but Madam Herta was insistent on meeting today. She mentioned a new parameter that she needs to analyze urgently.
>
> We tried to ask for more information, but she can be evasive when she wants to be.
>
> Himeko and I will be with Phainon and Tribios the whole time. I give you my word that they will be safe.

Chrysos Heirs

> **Cipher:** Ugh, the Station is sooo boring to play in, but I did my part last time. It’s your turn now *@Tribios @Phainon*, do some nasty damage!
>
> **Aglaea:** Do not do some nasty damage.
>
> **Tribios:** I just got the message, see you at the *Eschatheion*, Snowy! Also De, don’t frown too much. You’ll scare the honor guards.
>
> **Anaxagoras:** *@Aglaea* Stop ignoring my messages.

Aglaea: What a spectacular morning. The weather is sublime. The *Eschatheion* will look particularly bright today, don't you all think?

Aglaea: Anyway. Teacher, Phainon, I've approved the request. Please be ready by Ascent Hour. Herta wants to start as soon as poosible.

Mydei must be making a ferocious face, because Phainon wraps his arms around him and kisses his cheek. "It can't be helped," Phainon says, extricating the teleslate from Mydei's grip.

"The one they want is you. They're only asking for Tribios out of courtesy," Mydei replies sharply, tilting his head to give Phainon more room. "It's insulting. You are not a dog the Station can just call on whenever they wish."

Phainon chuckles, pressing little kisses down Mydei's neck. He reaches the divot where it meets the shoulder and murmurs, "Woof."

Ridiculous. Mydei fights the smile pulling at his lips. It shouldn't be allowed, how quickly that settles his nerves. "They'll keep you and Tribios for a day," he says, turning to properly face Phainon. "Are you really okay with that?"

Phainon hums, linking their hands under the water. "Aglaea and the Trailblazers trust them. As peculiar as Madam Herta and the rest of the Station may be, I believe they're doing their best to help us in the long run."

"I question their intentions when they come at your expense," Mydei says.

"It's hardly an expense, compared to everything else I've done."

Mydei says, low and firm, "Don't measure it against the cycles. It's not a fair comparison. And cease offering yourself like a sacrifice at an altar that no longer exists."

It's an old back-and-forth between them. Amphoreus, in its transformation from data to reality, had shattered cosmic rules they hadn't known existed. That came with a cost beyond the ones Phainon bore on his skin, in his soul.

Until Amphoreus accumulates enough memoria to stabilize itself in the Cosmos, it is Phainon —out of all the Heirs—who will remain under the closest scrutiny from the Trailblazers' Erudition allies. It is the unspoken agreement for their support, a temporary stopgate against the more dangerous interests of the Cosmos.

Mydei abhors the compromise, if it can even be called that. Gathering of memoria takes time, time no amount of Mydei's fury or yearning can hasten. If he could, he would drag the stars into alignment himself to relieve his husband of another burden he shouldn't have to carry.

Phainon's eyes are soft and imploring as he rests his palm on Mydei's cheek, thumb brushing over his tattoo. "Okay, okay," he soothes, "I'll speak to Caelus. See if he can help us leave sooner. He owes us that at least, with how much he riled you up yesterday."

Mydei exhales. “Between him and Stelle, he was fine.” He leans into Phainon’s touch. “Though I question what goes in both their heads sometimes.”

“Perhaps he’ll tell you once he knows you won’t pummel him into the ground for, what did you say yesterday? Challenging your patience?”

“As if Dan Heng would even let me near him with my gauntlets.”

Phainon cackles. “You’ve noticed that too?”

Mydei gives him a pointed look and nips at his palm. “You don’t get to talk. You’re just as bad as he is.”

Phainon’s laugh mellows into something warmer and sweeter. “That’s how we are when we have someone precious to protect,” he says, rich with teasing affection. His gaze is a heavy, deliberate thing, settling on Mydei like silk sliding over bare skin.

Warmth floods Mydei’s face. It’s worse knowing Phainon can feel it.

He doesn’t need to be protected. It wasn’t a luxury afforded to him during his formative years. He’s long learned to live without it, hardened himself against the absence. But a deep, brutally honest part of him thrills in knowing he has Phainon’s. Not just his protection, but his devotion. Wholly. Unconditionally.

Mydei quickly looks away, the feel of Phainon’s hand lingering. The tips of his ears burn. His fingertips tingle. He wants his husband again, and not just once more. “*HKS*. Hurry up and bathe. You’re going to be late.”

It’s a weak retort, spoken hoarsely, but Phainon chooses to be magnanimous. He grins and presses a chaste kiss to Mydei’s cheek. “Come then, Mydeimos. Let’s not make the world wait any longer.”

“Snowy!” Tribios sweeps Phainon into her arms, squeezing tightly. “Look at you, aren’t you all spiffied up!”

“Thank you,” Phainon wheezes, “Lady Tribios, my ribs.”

She gasps, releasing him. “I’m sorry—I keep forgetting my strength. It's taking a while to get used to, you know, this.”

In her current state, she nearly rivals Mydei in height. Her scarlet hair cascades to below her waist, dotted throughout with flowers in multiples of three. She looks well, healthy and glowing.

“So handsome!” Tribios continues to gush, twirling her finger and giggling as Phainon indulges her with a dramatic spin. “What’s the occasion? If I had known we’d be dressing fancy, I’d have worn my nicer clothes!”

“Ask Mydei,” Phainon says dryly. “Apparently dressing myself is a threat to interstellar peace.”

Mydei’s side-eye could make stone sweat. He opens the gallery on his teleslate. “It might have been, with that awful himation you tried to sneak past me this morning.”

“It wasn’t that bad,” Phainon argues hopelessly as Tribios nearly laughs herself into tears over the photoslate Mydei shows her. “It wasn’t—I thought it would match the aesthetic of the Station!”

“It was seven different shades of gray,” Mydei stresses. He ushers them toward the *Eschatheion*, where a crowd is beginning to gather. “I do not wish to ask how you procured such a thing. At least you look somewhat respectable now.”

It’s a bit of an understatement. His husband has always been attractive. That was never in doubt, even when Mydei knew nothing of him except his skill with the sword, until years later when Phainon defied Destruction itself, golden-haloed and dark-winged and cleaving stars apart.

But now Phainon draws the eye far too easily in his new ensemble: gossamer gold and wine-dark robes swishing around his ankles, pauldron and armor polished to a shine. Twin plaits sweep back from his temples, secured with the gold clasp which matches the thick gold bands wrapped above each sizable bicep.

He looks regal. A kindly king, smiling and sure against the bright blue sky of Dawncloud.

Mydei’s chest suddenly tightens, conflicted between ferocious pride and the instinct to draw Phainon back to his side where they can keep each other safe. The sentiment only intensifies when the crowd bursts with giggles as Phainon waves at them.

He’s not jealous, truly. There is no reason for him to be, and never has been. That is *his* husband. His equal for life and whatever comes after. Okhema knows it, oddly enough revels in it.

But the Cosmos is an unfamiliar battlefield, with far too many unknowns, few allies, and even fewer friends. Phainon represents Amphoreus on a scale completely different to that of the Senate or the Council. In a few minutes, he’ll be leagues away from Okhema, from the other Heirs. From Mydei. Tribios is strong, so strong in her own way, but she cannot parse the intentions and ambitions of others in the martial way that Mydei can, were he able to go himself.

“Mydei,” Phainon calls, with a note of concern. He’s standing in front of the platform with Tribios and the honor guards. He points up. “They’re activating it.”

The crowd hushes as Mydei strides forward. Behind Phainon and Tribios, the *Eschatheion*—the Great Bridge Beyond the Sky—begins to materialize, a beam of pure white light that will take them to the stars where the Trailblazers will receive them safely.

Phainon gazes at him. “Alright?” It’s intimate enough, tender enough to make Mydei’s teeth ache.

He rips apart his foolish, floundering thoughts. So unbecoming. Phainon is not a sun that the stars may claim as one of their own. Not anymore.

The honor guards of the *Eschatheion* take one glance at Mydei’s face and look away politely. Tribios feigns admiration of a nearby statue. Several teleslates whip out among the crowd.

Mydei pays them little mind as he cups his husband’s face, mindful of the gauntlet’s sharp edges. “Be careful while you’re there. Call out to me should you need help.”

Phainon covers his hand with his own. “We’ll be fine. Just a day, and we’ll be right back.”

“Next time, I will be going with you,” Mydei declares. “It’s unwise to keep separating like this. We should not let the Station divide the Heirs as they please.”

“I’ll speak to the Trailblazers and Madam Herta,” Phainon says, nuzzling into Mydei’s palm. “We’ll have to think of something to give in return.”

A shadow must cross over Mydei’s expression, because Phainon adds gently, that only Mydei can hear, “You know we need the Station’s support until we can stand on our own. The Cosmos are watching and we’ve only just begun to rebuild. If we hesitate or falter now, they’ll see weakness.”

He’s not wrong. In the eyes of the stars, Amphoreus is a ripe fruit ready to be plucked and devoured. A fertile ground for exploration and experimentation. Or conquest. It was inevitable. Their world birthed a story that drew the gaze of not just one, but three Aeons. It was a blessing, a warning, and a divine reckoning all at once.

From what the crew of the Express told them, dozens of galactic systems are already in motion, hungry to stake their claim in the path Amphoreus would take.

Spurred by the thought, Mydei presses their foreheads together. The tips of their noses brush. His hand curls over the leather band covering the mark of the sun. Mydei says roughly, “Who is weak? Let them come. I’ll be glad to test their mettle and show them a taste of Strife.”

Amphoreus has guardians of its own, now, and stalwart allies along the silver rail. The Chrysos Heirs would never permit Amphoreus to sink back into the despair of fated cycles, and the Trailblazers would never permit them to face fate alone again.

Phainon smiles, eyes fluttering shut. He slips one arm around Mydei’s back. His palm, warm and broad, covers the tenth thoracic vertebra. “Careful now, Mydei. With such an open invitation, you might find a worthy opponent who’ll impress you even by your Kremnoan standards, and then what will I do?”

“Of all things, that is what you focused on?” Mydei scolds. He closes his eyes too. His hands slide from Phainon’s face to his waist, holding him close. “Do I worry myself like that when

you have to meet with those men from the Xianzhou or Penacony? Concern yourself with finishing your mission in haste."

"Why must I be in haste?" Phainon teases. "Don't tell me the Guardian of Amphoreus is already itching for another spar? I didn't think you'd be so eager to be handed another loss."

"The Guardian of Amphoreus," Mydei mimics in Phainon's exact tone, drinking in the laugh Phainon gives out, "thinks that the Deliverer of Amphoreus should exert more effort in recalling exactly who got the final hit in during the last bout."

"Mmm, was it perhaps me, when I got you on your back for the third time that day?"

Mydei tightens his grip as he husks, "If I remember correctly, it was *you* on your back that fourth time."

Phainon draws back in surprise at his daring. His eyes widen briefly before darkening, half-lidded. It's a look Mydei knows well, one that leads to heated tumbles behind closed doors or, on a few special occasions, their balcony, the Hero's Bath at midnight, a particularly secluded corner of Kephale Square…

There's a wave of muffled squeals and swoons from the crowd. Tribios clears her throat. The *Eschatheion* pulses impatiently, now a near solid panel of white light behind her and the blushing honor guards.

Mydei blinks. When had the *Eschatheion* fully activated? When did the crowd swell to nearly hundreds in number?

"Whoops," Phainon says, not sounding the least bit sorry or surprised. He grins. "I win. You blinked first."

Mydei scowls, mostly out of principle. "I'm still in the lead. By a wide margin, by the way."

"Sure, if you're deliberately don't count the times when—"

"Snowy, De," Tribios interrupts, obviously fighting her mirth. "We can't delay anymore. You two can pick this up once we get back."

Phainon gives her an apologetic smile, letting go of Mydei. "To be continued," he says, a promise. "Duty calls."

"Mm. Remember what I said." Mydei lifts his chin, readying himself.

"Don't I always?" Phainon winks and turns away to walk toward Tribios.

Mydei is left standing, lips slightly parted.

Which, what.

The crowd titters. Tribios covers her mouth. One of the honor guards, a Kremnoan, places his face in his palms.

What.

"*HKS*," Mydei hisses, crossing the distance in loud stomps. His tattoos flare out bright and obvious.

Phainon glances over his shoulder, pretending to look confused. He's not a good actor. His eyes glimmer with mischief, with a challenge. *Come and get me*.

Mydei seizes his shoulders, spins him around, and kisses him hard. With tongue. Sweet vengeance.

The crowd's cheers are deafening.

"That," Mydei snaps, licking his lips as he releases Phainon, "is how you do a proper farewell."

"I see," Phainon breathes, starry-eyed. "Maybe you can demonstrate again? Just one more time?"

Mydei shoves him into the middle of *Eschatheion*. Tribios glides into place next to Phainon, her peals of laughter like bells. "Return when you promised, Deliverer. Or I'll come and bring you back myself." He nods to Tribios. "Be safe, both of you."

"Bye, De!" Tribios links her arm with Phainon's. She waves. "See you tomorrow!"

Phainon cups his mouth. "See you tomorrow, Mydei! *I love you*!" he shouts, unabashed and grinning brighter than the bridge to the stars.

The crowd swoons. Mydei doesn't notice them. His attention is fixed on Phainon, caped in luminous starry white. Kremnos' braids in his hair. Armored and adorned in Okheman ruby and gold, bearing sigils marked by each Chrysos Heir. Beautiful, and maddening. Unshaken.

Mydei's smile hurts with pride. He lifts a hand. Phainon's words wrap around him like armor, like a blanket, like an embrace. He'll say them back when his husband returns victorious, and more.

You too. *I'll be waiting*.

A flash of bright light, like lightning in the distance. Then Phainon and Tribios are gone. Dust kicks up in the absence of the *Eschatheion*.

And now, Mydei thinks as he faces hundreds of emotional citizens with teleslates poised and an honor guard that only reddens more when he tries to catch their eyes—he has his own battle to fight.

Krateros doesn't laugh, but it's the closest Mydei has ever seen him do so.

"The Okhemas gave you a hard time?" He hedges, falling into step beside Mydei as they walk toward the detachment's part of the city.

Mydei shakes his head, exhausted. “It wasn’t just Okhemans. More than a quarter of them were our people. One of them tried to pat me and said Phainon would be back soon.” He pinches the bridge of his nose. “I know he’ll be back soon. They’re more worked up than I am.”

Krateros grunts. “I do not blame them. An army that lets one of its generals walk into the enemy’s camp is not fit to conquer even the smallest village.”

Mydei’s knee-jerk instinct is to protest. To wage war on the Cosmos is a death knell for Amphoreus, no matter how strong the Heirs may be. Phainon didn’t endure millions of cycles to spearhead cosmic warfare, quite the opposite, and the mantle of military leadership is the last thing Mydei wants for his husband.

But Mydei’s tired beyond words, of which he would need many to debate with his teacher. It is Krateros’ way, the old and true Kremnoan way, to think in terms of strategy and battle and troops. It is also Mydei’s way, but not his only one. Securing the future of Amphoreus will need many different approaches; the Heirs’ compromise with the Station being case in point.

“The Station is not our enemy. We need their help, and they need our cooperation,” Mydei reminds him. “It’s a partnership that suits us for the time being.”

“Until Lord Phainon’s condition stabilizes, I assume?”

Krateros’ tone is odd. Not hesitant, but a shade of it. Mydei glances at him. His teacher’s face gives nothing away.

“Yes,” Mydei acquieses. “Until Phainon is better.”

Krateros is quiet as they stroll. They’re nearly past the Marmoreal Palace when he says, “It’s time to officially announce it to our people, then.”

“Announce what?” Mydei asks absently, noticing multiple clusters of people in and around the baths. Animated debates, by the looks of it.

“Lord Phainon’s condition?” Krateros sounds confused.

Mydei frowns, facing him. “The people know of it, Teacher. It’s obvious.” They have made no effort to hide Phainon’s *rhimágmata* since the beginning.

Krateros crosses his arms disapprovingly. “We should not wait until Lord Phainon is showing. Our people should hear it from the mouth of their regent, not from whispers on the streets or those silly teleslates. A royal pregnancy is no small matter, Mydeimos.”

Mydei stumbles. Krateros catches his shoulder.

“A royal—a royal what?” Mydei exclaims.

They stare at each other, equally stupified.

“You said—” Krateros says, voice cracking.

“I know what I said but—” Mydei says, high-pitched.

“You just confirmed it—”

“That’s not what I meant—”

Severely, Krateros interjects, “I know fatherhood is a difficult subject, even more so for our people and yourself, but you should honor your consort and proclaim the new heir to the people—”

“There is no heir, Phainon is—”

“—the inheritor of the Worldbearer’s divinity, and hence best suited to bear a child of miracles!” someone shouts from the baths. It echoes through the hall, followed by a cacophony of voices, thumps of fists, and clatters of goblets on marble and stone.

The world stops, flips over, and punches Mydei square in the chest. The next thing he knows, he’s pushing through the crowds, panic and Krateros close at his heels. He has to find the source, has to know the full context of that sentence.

In the middle of the Bath of Plenty, nearly a hundred people form a circle. Several figures stand in the middle, huffing and puffing as if having run a marathon.

A woman gowned in the Grove’s colors glares at a man with gold foil in his long hair. She announces, sharp and cutting, “Approaching this from the angle of divinity is short-sighted. Interpretations of the Titans’ divine powers have fluctuated every Era. Just because Lord Phainon is a demigod doesn’t mean he can somehow defy basic anatomy and conceive a child. He is still a man.”

The long-haired man crosses his arms. “I would have thought a scholar of the Grove to not be so close-minded. Lord Phainon is not merely a man. He is a Chrysos Heir and the Deliverer of the Dawn. Within him is the divinity of Kephale, the Father of Creation. What other authority can grant exceptions to our mortal rules?”

The Grove scholar scoffs. “Where does it say in any of the theological scriptures that Kephale can permit pregnancy in the male form?”

“Once again,” the long-haired man says, enunciating each syllable, “you are so fixated on Lord Phainon’s male form that you are blinded to the greater implications of his demigod status—”

“Blinded?” the Grove scholar repeats, hands curling into fists.

Quickly, a woman with a purple sash decorated with butterflies steps forward. “Why are we still debating the possibility of conception when there’s already more than enough evidence that the Deliverer is *carrying*?”

A roar of reactions fills the baths. Disbelieving gasps, loud cheers; someone says from the upper balcony: “Hear, hear.”

The long-haired man raises his hands, backtracking. “I believe that’s a bit too hasty a conjecture at this point in time.”

“The signs are quite clear,” the woman continues fervently, waving her hands. “Glowing skin. Looser robes. Needing to be carried by his lord husband to their rooms, even!”

There are multiple rounds of dreamy sighs.

The Grove scholar pointedly says, “That theory has even less evidence than Lord Phainon being able to grow a womb.”

Another voice chimes in from the edge of the circle: “Who are we to say Lord Phainon requires a womb? The Father of Creation birthed humanity through breath alone—”

“Are we to put such stock in myth and metaphor—” the Grove scholar snaps, but someone else from a gaggle of pink-robed librarians thrusts a scroll midair.

“Whether or not Lord Phainon possessed a womb before is immaterial!” the new participant declares confidently. “Based on this book that the heroes from beyond the sky gifted us, it is entirely probable that divinity can awaken latent instincts beyond the prescribed abilities of the demigods—changing things like their natural scents and even genitalia to accommodate a pregnancy!”

Several people raise their goblets in enthusiastic toast, while others cringe and shake their heads. More and more citizens join the circle. Some are wrapped in towels, others half-dressed in bath robes. Wine and water slosh onto the floors.

A woman near the fountain calls out, sounding frustrated, “Shouldn’t we be celebrating the possibility instead of interrogating it? Era Nova is now upon us, thanks to the Chrysos Heirs and their comrades. If Lord Phainon truly carries a child, it is a blessed one. Let us honor it!”

A voice barks from atop a bench, “You want to celebrate a rumor? Do you not think that Lord Phainon and his husband would have announced such a momentous occasion were it true? Why are all of you so eager to hasten falsehoods?”

A man insists over the din, “I heard from my second cousin’s wife’s nephew-in-law that his neighbor saw Lord Mydeimos purchasing a basket of conception medicine yesterday morning!”

“You fool,” another man says from the opposite side. “What kind of source reliability is that? I was actually there at Marmoreal Market yesterday. The Prince was just buying vegetables and fruits from Demetria—”

“Who buys cremni pear if not for pregnancy?” the first man demands.

“Cremni pear can be used for any muscle ache, you oaf—”

“Who are you calling an oaf!”

The two lunge at each other and wrestle in the shallows of the pool. They're swallowed up by the crowd.

"Why are we putting all the burden of proof on Lord Phainon?" drawls a young woman lounging on a kline. "Last time I checked, it takes at least two people to make a child. Lord Phainon's obviously able to bear one, with those hips of his, but why are we not questioning the position of Lord Mydeimos? No offense, but maybe he's the infertile one."

Brief, sparse mutterings of agreement are instantly drowned out by a tide of angry shouts.

"Take that back!" A Kremnoan wades toward the young woman, looking furious. "Prince Mydeimos is Lord Phainon's lawful husband. He is the embodiment of Strife who stood alone against the black tide—you think someone like him can't sire a child?"

"Perhaps that time alone with the black tide rendered his seed moot—"

"Are you calling our Prince impotent?!"

There are slaps and shoves. A sandal flies across the room. It hits someone else entirely. Numerous scuffles break out.

"Blasphemy!"

"Prudence!"

"Preposterous!"

"Lord Phainon deserves peace, not prodding!" a bath attendant yells, hoisting a bath bucket defensively.

"So we should just ignore the biggest miracle since Era Nova?" another snaps, wielding a pair of soapstones. "He's not just anyone! If he's with child, Okhema should rejoice!"

Two muscular bathers stand chest to chest, veins bulging. The taller one says, "If Lord Phainon carries the heir to your kingdom, why did your prince let him go beyond the sky when he should be resting in confinement?"

The other bather sneers. "We do not treat our mothers like delicate flowers. Lord Phainon is the Crown Prince's only equal. He alone is strong enough to carry the blessed heir and carry out his mission beyond the sky. And *unlike* others, we have full trust in our prince-consort's capabilities—"

He's tackled into the water. The baths reverberate with yells, swearing, more splashing. An entire fruit platter is hurled like a discus across the pool. It hits the pink-robed scholars with a wet splat, triggering another brawl.

The Grove scholar tries to shout over the chaos, "Order! Calm yourselves and be rational!"

She's promptly jostled aside by a wide-eyed man with his hands folded in prayer. He chants over and over, "The star signs did not lie, the star signs did *not* lie, I knew it the moment I

saw that constellation!"

"Lord Mydei," Castorice says.

Mydei jolts out of his stupor. Castorice hovers over him, wringing her hands. He's sitting on a kline with a goblet of juice in one hand. He downs it in one gulp. His head spins, full of cotton. His heart is pounding hard. Behind Castorice, Krateros is alternating between watching the debacle and scrutinizing him.

"Cas," Mydei rasps when he finds his voice, "I think the city's gone mad."

She gives him a wan smile. "Come, let's get you to your rooms. It's getting much too wild here."

Mydei numbly lets her and Krateros guide him back to the Heirs' apartments. It's not until he's slumped over on the floor of his and Phainon's room with the chimeras sniffing at him that he's able to think coherently again.

Krateros stands in the hallway, looking pensive. He mutters something to Castorice. She nods and quietly closes the door before joining Mydei on the floor.

They say nothing for a few minutes. Beagle Coconut starts to make biscuits on Mydei's lap. Honey Fruitcake perches in the crook of Castorice's elbow and watches his mate contentedly. Mydei, in a rare moment of weakness, flops onto his back, holding Beagle Coconut so he doesn't startle. Castorice does the same.

Mydei musters himself and says to the ceiling, "Cas?"

"Hmm?"

"Why are the people debating about Phainon having—Phainon being able to—" The words traitorously clog up in his throat.

Castorice says, very softly, "To get pregnant?"

Mydei makes a strangled noise. "Yes," he chokes. "That."

Castorice reaches out and, after a brief second of hesitation, lays a gentle hand on his wrist. Her skin is cooler than Mydei's, but comforting. She replies, "The Titan of Worldbearing has always been a heated topic of debate."

"Has," Mydei swallows. "Has the debate always focused on that part, though?"

Castorice is quiet, then, "It's become more popular, recently."

Mydei stares at the ceiling.

"Lord Mydei?"

"Just Mydei, Cas."

“Mydei,” Castorice says. “Are you angry? That people are talking about it?”

Is he? Is anger the feeling that tingles at the base of his spine when he thinks of Phainon and pregnancy in the same sentence, or a different sort of madness? Is it fury at a perceived insult that makes his jaw clench every time someone speaks of Phainon conceiving, Phainon carrying—or something else entirely?

“No,” Mydei says. “I’m not angry.”

“Oh.” He can feel the relief radiating from Castorice. “That’s good to hear.”

He thinks about yesterday, and today, and feels a little raw. “Cas, the thing that made me crystallize Marmoreal Market.”

“I heard,” she says not unkindly. “Stelle and Caelus are many things, but they are not subtle.” She pauses. “I—I suppose I wasn’t subtle as well, when the topic was brought up in the baths a few days ago.”

“Is that why you were in the baths today? Because of the debate?”

Castorice admits meekly, “I wanted to hear the other theories.”

Tension drains out of him. He sighs. “So… last time, did Caelus really almost get into a fight?”

Castorice laughs, light as a butterfly’s wing. “Yes. Dan Heng smiled a lot that day.”

“I can imagine.” Lucky man. Phainon in full righteous anger is quite a treat himself, but Mydei hasn’t seen him like that since the first Council meeting after the First Dawn. Perhaps they should join another one later this week.

Beagle Coconut falls asleep on Mydei. Honey Fruitcake slips from Castorice’s arm, waddles over Mydei, and hops on his belly to curl protectively around his mate. Mydei huffs but lays a hand over them both.

They ponder the ceiling in comfortable silence. His heart no longer feels like it’s about to break out between his ribs when his teleslate buzzes, followed by Castorice’s.

“I’ll take care of it,” Castorice says, already thumbing a response.

“How bad is it?”

Castorice reads her teleslate. “Not bad, actually. Lady Aglaea and Hyacine sorted out the baths. Cifera mentioned some acolytes who followed Zagreus may have gotten to the wine.” She raises a brow at something Cipher must have typed. “She neither claims nor denies involvement. She does say your and Lord Phainon’s moment at the *Eschatheion* helped.”

“She saw us?”

“Both of you are on the front page of the news.” Castorice shows him the screen. His and Phainon’s embrace is on full colored display, complete with the crowd cheering in the background.

It’s a photoslate that will absolutely circulate throughout Amphoreus within the day, if not the hour. Underneath are comments from countless citizens, which continue for several hundred pages. Mydei’s eyes glaze over just thinking about reading them, but a quick scan over the first page tells him enough.

“Mydei?” Castorice touches his arm. “Are you okay?”

“Most of them are quite convinced,” he says, “about Phainon being able to, uh.”

“Get pregnant?” Castorice supplies helpfully, reading from the comments. “Bear the world? Bring a new dawn?”

“Do you think he can?” Mydei blurts out.

Castorice’s gaze falls to her lap. “Perhaps the only one who can answer that is Phainon himself.” She takes a deep breath and meets Mydei’s eyes. “But I think what’s more important is, how do you feel about that? Whether or not he’s able to?”

To think about it is a struggle in itself. A churn of odd shame and inexplicable want burns under his skin. His whole body trembles, alight with something brighter and fiercer than any Coreflame.

Castorice picks up on it. Her expression softens. “You don’t have to have the answer now. Take some time and think about it.” She smoothes out her skirt and stands. “I’ll be visiting the dromases today. Would you like to join me?”

Mydei, for lack of anything else and in desperate need for company, can only agree. He deposits the chimeras on the kline, freshens up, and lets Castorice take the lead for the day.

They visit the dromases; Mydei gives Kokopo the Third a thorough cleaning, partly to give his hands something to do. Castorice somehow manages to maneuver the dromases to stand around them, blocking Mydei from inquisitive onlookers.

Lunch is taken picnic-style with Hyacine in the Garden of Life. Mydei freezes when Aglaea glides onto the sunlit pavilion, but she simply tops off his juice and finishes half of the tiropitakias, famished. Hyacine falls asleep midway, stretched out on the grass, exhausted from the surge of injuries from the baths.

“Rest,” Aglaea tells him, reclining on the blanket. “I believe we shall all need it in the coming days.”

“What does that mean,” Mydei wants to ask out of reflex. He decides not to, choosing to preserve the delicate peace. He joins them on the cool soft grass and closes his eyes.

The day passes in a similar fashion, attending to other matters around Okhema. Surveying the rebuilding of the Path of Parting. Looking over the archives of the detachment’s makeshift

library. Organizing the newest batch of chimeras into their work teams.

Castorice accompanies Mydei the whole time. He suspects she purposefully planned places to go where the citizens can't easily follow them. He's grateful for her. But from the way Cipher keeps spamming Mydei's private messages, she and Castorice seem to have something planned for the evening.

"It's no trouble at all," Castorice keeps insisting as they walk the hallway to Mydei and Phainon's rooms. "Come join us for dinner. We'll take a stroll around Okhema. Perhaps we can stargaze later tonight."

"*I* might take a walk," Mydei teases. "*You* might gaze at something else entirely."

"Mydei!" She covers her face. "It's not like that!"

"Don't let me keep you," he urges. "I'll be fine. I have to take care of the chimeras anyway."

Castorice peeks at him through her fingers. "You're sure?"

"I'm sure," Mydei says solemnly. "You deserve this, too. Go enjoy yourself."

Castorice's cheeks are tinged a light pink as she bids Mydei farewell. Mydei watches her leave before sending a conciliatory message to Cipher and going inside.

"I'm home," he says to Beagle Coconut and Honey Fruitcake. They crowd his feet, awoo-ing insistently. "Hungry?"

He fixes the chimeras' dinner and watches them eat, not having much of an appetite himself. The sun is starting to set, filling the room with honey-golden light. It's the kind of view he and Phainon would watch from the balcony, a platter of fine cheeses and fresh fruits balanced between them as they spoke about everything, and sometimes nothing.

He steps onto the balcony. It welcomes him with a sky awash with rose and gold. But it doesn't feel the same. Not like when it hugs the curve of Phainon's cheek, catching on a smile meant only for his husband—holding it there, as if time couldn't bear to let go.

Strife. Feeling somewhat forlorn and foolish because of it, Mydei checks his teleslate. No new messages from Phainon. It's normal. Communication between Amphoreus and the Station is unreliable at best. It's also not late enough in the day that Phainon or Tribios would return to the Express, where Phainon would call Mydei.

Mydei closes the inbox and spots the photoslate from earlier. His finger hovers over it. He can't help but think back to his conversation with Castorice, replaying each moment in slow detail.

He ruled out having children long before he met Phainon. The weight of his lineage and the dark, overglossed custom of patricide in Castrum Kremnos had made the idea unbearable. He refused to subject any child to the weight he once carried, or be forced to do what he'd done to Eurypon.

But here in Okhema, he's grown fond of little ones running afoot, the sound of their laughter ringing in the streets, the halls. He watched Kremnoan children grow up in the Holy City, unburdened by the expectation of martyrdom in Nikador's name. Ending the dynasty had not doomed them. It had been its own kind of mercy, giving them a new beginning.

Phainon, he knows, grew up with many children around Aedes Elysiae. He lost them too, countless times across countless cycles. But the grief hadn't stopped him from letting the city's children swing from his arms, or dragging him into games during patrol breaks. He laughs at their jokes and listens to their stories. He kneels when they run to him.

Yet they've never spoken of adopting or having any of their own. Era Nova brought with it a new set of challenges, far-reaching and far more complex than they had imagined. Their duties as Chrysos Heirs had not ended with the First Dawn.

Mydei's eyes fall back to the photoslate.

Whatever flicker of embarrassment he might have felt is eclipsed by something deeper, more powerful. An ache that takes his breath away.

He has seen his husband in rage, in sorrow, in unspeakable grief. He's also seen him in laughter, in luminous joy, decadently in love and unashamed of it in Mydei's arms.

In the photoslate, with their bodies fitted together like puzzle pieces, Phainon glows. The one who bears the world, at peace.

Would he still glow, cradling a child with Mydei's smile and his own blue eyes? What would he look like, carrying another—who might inherit Mydei's nose and Phainon's hair, a tiny echo of them both? Would Phainon be as content with a third? A fourth? Would he be at peace in a home filled with ruckus laughter, and little hands reaching up to them both?

Mydei's heart could be in tatters, for the way longing carves through it.

Oh, he thinks. Then, *I have to talk to Phainon*.

Beloved

Praise the sun!

> Mydei, I know it's later than usual, but we're back on the Express. You might be asleep already, so I'll call you tomorrow.
>
> So much happened today at the Station, a lot of it quite strange. Madam Herta's line of questioning was completely different than before. She seemed more… caring? Maybe that's not the word. Perhaps cautious?
>
> The crew has also been hovering more so than usual. Sunday in particular has stuck to my side. He said something about "warding off disharmonious energies" which I thought was kind of him.
>
> I'll tell you the whole of it in the morning. For now, goodnight and rest easy.

I miss you already, my lion.

Anaxagoras
Then let me ask you

Crown Prince,

Perhaps there is still something more I can teach you.

I expect you at the Grove tomorrow, at the start of Lucid Hour.

We will speak—uninterrupted.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: crystal lizard satay is a real in-game consumable! It recovers 4 Technique Points, but each team member loses 15% of their Max HP. Did Caelus and Stelle know that beforehand? Probably not, with their iron stomachs.

On an unrelated note, I, too, would participate in a baths brawl over Mydei and Phainon and their potential future cosmic babies.

(Formatting edited as of August 1, 2025)

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> The air leaves Mydei's lungs. He stares at Anaxa's back. Anaxa looks over his shoulder with an arched brow. "So shocked, Crown Prince. Is that not why we are here?"
>
> "You believe it to be possible?" Mydei asks, voice tremulous despite himself.
>
> "Which part? That Phainon can bear children or that you want so ardently for him to do so?"

Chapter Notes

> Apologies for the late update! I moved, got sick (still sick), and had a few major life changes… thanks again for so many lovely comments and the support!
>
> No beta, and all of this was edited on mobile, so please pardon any formatting or other errors.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei does not know what to expect when he steps down from the Space Anchor.

Perhaps a legion of loyal Nousporists ready to march him to the Luminary Throne. Maybe one of Anaxa's contraptions, ready to spring on him in the name of field trial experimentation. Or even the Sage himself, waiting patiently with his gun aimed at Mydei's crotch.

Given Anaxa's taste for the theatrics, Mydei would not have been surprised if the man has gone out of his way to make answering his summons as difficult as possible. Especially when today's meeting undoubtedly concerns Phainon.

For a man who claims the position of teacher alone, Anaxa plays the role of father far too convincingly.

But perhaps Mydei is being overly imaginative, and rather unfair to Anaxa. Exhaustion gnaws at him down to the bone. A night tossing and turning and ruminating over yesterday's revelations has left him drained in a way fighting titankin never had. Rest had eluded him and thus his brain has, on the worst possible day, turned into mush.

So when he arrives at the Grove, the sight of Stelle sitting criss-crossed on a bench at the head of the Woven Path, serenely braiding three strands of long grass, is enough to make him stop in his tracks and briefly doubt his own eyes.

Stelle brightens up upon seeing him, tucking the braided grass into her pocket. She waves enthusiastically. “Hi Mydei!”

This shameless woman. Does she have any idea of the domino effect she and her brother have started? He rounds on her with a newfound surge of energy. “*Trailblazer*—”

Stelle yelps, scrambling off the bench. “Mercy, Mydei! I come in peace!”

“I hope you come bearing an explanation,” Mydei thunders, “and twenty-five thousand balance coins.”

Stelle pauses, one foot hovering in the air. “Only twenty-five?”

“Phainon will get the other twenty-five out of Caelus. Now get back over here.”

Stelle squeaks and hops out of range of his gauntlets. “Five minutes is all I ask! Mydei!” she whines with the same intonation Phainon uses.

Unfortunately for her, the rendition lacks the big blue puppy eyes that make it work. Mydei crosses his arms, schooling his face into stone. “Speak.”

“Okay, so in the beginning—” Stelle stops, frowning. “Actually, I might need more than five minutes, unless you want the super abridged version.”

“What manner of explanation,” Mydei says, “could possibly necessitate an abridged version?”

Stelle seems to think very deeply. She counts something on her fingers, then draws some nonsensical shapes in the air. After a few seconds of this, she says, “So do you remember how in Cycle Zero—”

“I no longer wish to know,” Mydei groans, palming the tension behind the bridge of his brows.

“This time though was because of a book about Kephale,” Stelle rolls over his protest, tiptoeing closer once she figures Mydei won’t yank her into a headlock. “We found it during the clean-up here. Dan Heng needed help translating it, so we asked some other scholars and, well…”

“The rest is history?” Mydei has a good idea now which parts of the book needed help translating.

She grins, the tiniest hint of mischief afoot. “History to be made?”

The base of his spine tingles. Strife makes its approval known as his *thymós* stirs under his skin, tattoos crackling scarlet. Stelle’s grin widens knowingly.

“That audacity will be your downfall,” Mydei grumbles. He bumps their shoulders lightly to soften the words. “Why are you here? I’d have thought you’d do everything in your power to avoid me, considering how fast you and Caelus fled Okhema.”

Stelle winces. “Anaxa mentioned you were coming. I wanted to come and say hi.” She rubs the back of her head. “I also wanted to apologize. Cas told me you might have had a rough day yesterday.”

Mydei shakes his head. “Keep your apologies and keep me company instead.” He starts up the Woven Path. “Though I warn you, I can’t guarantee your safety if you’re in my vicinity once Anaxagoras catches sight of me.”

Stelle falls in step beside him. Mydei extends his arm, which she takes with a happy squeal. “I don’t think he’s that mad.” At Mydei’s doubtful side-eye, she adds, “I mean it! He said a lot of really complicated words and made some things blow up yesterday in his lab, but he seemed fine this morning.”

Fantastic. Maybe Anaxa had expended enough energy to let Mydei crawl from the Grove mostly intact. Or maybe that’s wishful thinking. He says, “Anaxagoras could be splitting his soul into a dozen fragments and still say he’s fine.” Which he has, multiple times across many cycles.

“But better fine than not, right?” Stelle needles. “Speaking of, how are you doing? With everything that’s happened? I heard about the debate in the baths.”

“Debate is one way to put it. Castorice told you?”

Her eyes dart away. “Not just her.”

“Nevermind,” Mydei sighs. “I won’t be surprised if news of it has reached every corner of Amphoreus. Don’t let it weigh on you,” he says when Stelle looks at the ground guiltily. “I had time to think about it. I’m fine.”

She peeks at him. “Truly?

With heavy, weary eyes, Mydei looks to the sky. The sun is overcast by a smattering of puffy white clouds. If he was a more imaginative man, he might imagine Phainon looking his way, too. Might see the imperfect, crooked smile Phainon reserves just for him.

Urgency curls around quiet longing. It’s the feeling that’s kept him up all night, staring at the ceiling and seriously considering taking the *Eschatheion* to fetch Phainon from the Station himself. To see his face again. To know he’s safe. To sit him down and tell him the truth of the matter, and hear what he has to say.

“I will be, once I speak to Phainon about it,” Mydei tells Stelle.

She has a sort of bug-eyed look. Mydei attempts to lighten the mood. “If you were anticipating a… what do you and Caelus call it? A crashout? You are a bit late.”

“Who, how,” Stelle sputters. “Cas?”

“Not just her,” Mydei says, tugging her along, satisfied with the utter astonishment on her face. “There won’t be a repeat performance, by the way. You’ll have to get the full details on your own.”

“Mydei!” Stelle squawks before hurrying to keep up. “Hey slow down, each of your steps are two of mine, you know. Oi, Mydei!”

He takes the lead in crossing the bridges that connect the Grove’s rebuilt grounds. Classes must be in session, as there are no scholars outside. Construction tents have been set up along the way with teams of people from different city-states pouring over floor plans and drawings.

The Grove was among the few city-states unanimously voted for priority reconstruction, both out of respect and necessity. Remnants of the black tide still linger, and the unknown Cosmos hover above in the place of Aquila's threatening power.

Erudition has borne great fruits in Amphoreus. The Grove, its newly restored plethora of scholars and wealth of knowledge, remains one of their greatest strengths.

Mydei greets the reconstruction teams with a nod and a wave, which are returned enthusiastically. “How goes the recovery?” he asks Stelle as they pass the Serene Court of Learning.

Compared to the wreckage that the first days of Era Nova left behind, the change is striking. Stone walkways lie restored and swept clean. Grass has begun to regrow in wide patches. New pillars lift skyward with budding vines curling around the bases.

Stelle, who has so far been glancing at him like one might study a particularly colorful insect, startles and replies, “Ahead of schedule. Most of the Space Anchors are in place and the scholars’ dormitories are finished. We’re going to start bringing in the first batch of books into the Library of Philia today.”

“Oh?” Mydei says mildly. “Is the worldbearing book among them?”

Stelle’s grip tightens in shock as she wails, “Don’t call it that! It sounds so weird coming from you!”

“Is it not, as you and others have declared before, a book about Kephale? Who was the Worldbearing Titan?” He tilts his head, recalling the numerous arguments mentioned in the baths. “The Titan whose coreflame burns inside Phainon who is also called the Deliverer—”

“It’s too cringe in your voice,” Stelle cries. She’s the one to yank Mydei now, marching toward the Dome of Devotion. “Please hurry and get things cleared up with Anaxa so we can go treasure hunting and never talk about this again.”

Mydei snorts, letting himself be pulled inside the Dome. A cool air washes over him, sweet-smelling and fresh. Golden butterflies flutter around them, drawn to their chatter. One lands on Mydei’s gauntlet. Its glow is the same shade as Phainon’s eyes when Mydei first saw him at the new dawn of their world.

“They came back a few days ago,” Stelle says, beaming as a butterfly lands on her outstretched hand. They temper the sound of their footsteps, the volume of their voices. This is still, even after being ravaged by Destruction, a place for contemplation and reverence. “Not as many as before,” Stelle says, “but more than what we were expecting.”

Mydei hums, watching the golden butterflies leave faint traces of light in their paths. Much had been lost in the battle for Amphoreus, losses that Era Nova couldn’t wholly restore. A wealth of soul essence had bled away when they broke through the false sky.

By the time they catalogued the damage, most of the Creation Nymphs were gone.

“They’ll grow in number,” Mydei assures, letting his butterfly fly off before nudging Stelle’s arm. “It might take some time, but the next generation that follows will be free of their original code.”

She sniffles, swipes a hand across her nose, and nods fiercely. “Right! They don’t have to worry about being used as Irontomb’s data. They can just be butterflies and beetles and whatever else they want to be.” She coos to the butterfly on her hand, “Don’t worry, little one. We’ll never let you be part of that awful system ever again. I promise!”

Mydei smiles. *That’s the spirit, Trailblazer*. For all the headaches that Stelle and Caelus give him, shameless as they can be, they are the Heirs’ greatest friends and supporters. The new silver tracks glittering in the stars beyond the sky are proof of that.

With renewed vigor, Stelle marches them up the slope leading to the Luminary Throne. When they’re a few paces away, she turns to Mydei. “Ready?” she asks, disentangling their arms but holding onto his wrist.

Mydei takes in the entrance to the highest point of the Grove, outlined in moss and stone. A breeze floats down to them, bringing with it the faint smell of parchment and metal and herbs.

The Luminary Throne was never meant for a laboratory. *Too sacred*, the devout murmured, bowing their heads as they prayed. *Too storied*, noted the more cautious, wary of staking claim where a Titan’s Coreflame once slumbered. *Too remote*, a few confessed, for at such heights the stars provided closer company than people.

It only suited Anaxagoras to take those as recommendations, not warnings.

“Mydei?” Stelle murmurs with a squeeze of his wrist. Her eyes are solemn, focused, darting over his face as if trying to find something. “Want me to come with you? I can just stand to the side for moral support. I won’t even make a peep.”

Mydei chuckles. “Anaxa said he and I will speak uninterrupted. We both know he means for us to be alone.”

He wonders briefly if it was the salaciousness of the rumors, or the possibility of them having some kernel of truth, that prompted such a message from Anaxa. Theirs has always been a

cordial relationship strengthened by a love for learning and an appreciation for dromases. He can only hope he hasn't lost that mutual respect.

Stelle nods slowly and lets go. "I'll wait here then."

"Still want to see the show?"

She shakes her head and reaches inside her jacket, pulling out the grass braid. Upon closer inspection, Mydei realizes she's made it in the Kremnoan style using both orange and blue-green stalks of grass. Messy and uneven, but complete. "Think of it as being there for my friends," Stelle says, pressing the braid into his hand. "I've been practicing, see?"

Mydei smiles. "I see." He pats her head. "It's a worthy effort."

Stelle grins. "Good luck, Mydei. See you on the other side."

He can feel her gaze on his back as he ascends the last few steps to the Luminary Throne. The grass braid is a comforting weight in his pocket. The mossy walls around him give way to loamy earth, to thick branches that eventually part and reveal glimpses of clouds.

When he reaches the top, the sky above is somehow dark and star-studded. It hadn't even been a half a quint since he arrived. It should be around Lucid Hour. Mydei blinks, bewildered.

Then he spots Anaxagoras. The Sage's lithe form cuts a sharp picture where the Luminary Throne once stood, stark amidst stacks of books and tables of cauldrons.

Anaxagoras turns. His gun rests comfortably in its holster at his hip. Even from this distance, the metal on the handle gleams, freshly polished. Around them, gentle sifts of dusty light flow like currents, cosmic and almost arcane.

"Crown Prince," Anaxa greets. His voice, velvety and almost lyrical, warps through the space like a command.

"Anaxagoras—"

A bullet slashes past Mydei's cheek, barely missing him. Behind him, a stone pillar shatters. Red bleeds from Anaxa's eye and blurs into a streak as he takes position and aims again, his lips set in a neutral line.

So this is how it will be. Mydei accepts the challenge with solemn determination, as he has all challenges before.

The clearing ruptures with the ring of bullets, dirt exploding where Mydei stood not a second ago. Mydei dodges and weaves, ducks and spins, his tattoos flashing as his entire body thrums. The rhythm of battle is one that his body knows by heart, though the nature of this fight is a far cry from the norm.

"Anaxagoras," he calls out.

“Don’t interrupt me,” Anaxa replies coolly, and fires off another round that cuts a jagged line through the air and takes all of Mydei’s concentration to avoid.

Mydei won’t retaliate. There’s a lesson to this, he knows, and he tries to parse it from the patterns of Anaxa’s attacks. The man isn’t aiming to maim, that’s for sure; otherwise Mydei would have been riddled in holes from the moment he stepped onto the hallowed grounds.

Anaxa gives no quarter, not even as he reloads and watches the previous bullets ricochet around Mydei. Mydei’s gauntlets and boots leave deep grooves in the soil. Sweat gathers on his brow, in his palms.

Then, just as quickly as it started, it stops. Anaxa lifts his gun and checks the chamber with lazy nonchalance. Mydei breathes slowly, wiping dirt from his face. He expects Anaxa to reload again and start shooting for real.

Anaxa does not. He nods as if confirming something, holsters the gun, and crosses his arms as he meets Mydei’s eyes. “Your senses are as sharp as ever, Mydeimos,” he says casually, as if he hasn’t emptied entire clips into the floor, the walls.

Mydei straightens up and rasps, “You needed to use your gun to confirm that?”

“Experimentation is the best way to prove or disprove a theory.” Anaxa gestures to the bullet holes and damage around them. “As we’ve so demonstrated.”

“What theory necessitated such an experiment?” Mydei asks, eyeing him.

“Was I not clear enough in my message?”

Mydei says, “You wanted to teach me a lesson. Because of Phainon.” The last part wasn’t mentioned in Anaxa’s summons, but what else could possibly warrant such a display?

“Like I said, your senses remain sharp.” Anaxa turns back to the table, pushing through scrolls and trinkets. “Good. You’ll need that when you and Phainon decide to have children.”

The air leaves Mydei’s lungs. He stares at Anaxa’s back. Anaxa looks over his shoulder with an arched brow. “So shocked, Crown Prince. Is that not why we are here?”

“You believe it to be possible?” Mydei asks, voice tremulous despite himself.

“Which part? That Phainon can bear children or that you want so ardently for him to do so?”

An incredulous huff leaves Mydei at the sheer boldness of this man. “Let’s start with the first, perhaps.”

Anaxa turns and regards him with unsettling calm. There’s a small round object in his hands. “Phainon shattered a space-time dimension and drew an Aeon’s blood when he was nothing more than code. Do you think he is incapable of carrying a child as he is now?”

“You make the alternative sound like the greater impossibility,” Mydei confesses.

“I believe impossibility is not something Phainon concerns himself with,” Anaxa says smoothly.

In that, they are in agreement. Mydei swallows, tamping down his nerves. “Very well. Then the second? Am I so transparent?”

A wry smile plays on Anaxa’s lips. “On your part, yes. But that is to be expected. You are newly wedded to Kephale’s successor. Era Nova is upon us. Is it not part of the natural proclivity of humans in peacetime to sow seed and see it grow?”

Such a clinical, objective analysis. “It is better to raise children in peace than in war,” Mydei agrees. “But on Phainon’s part—I have yet to speak to him about it. The thought hadn’t even occurred to me until recently.” Until a day ago, in fact. How quickly his whole world can change.

Anaxa’s eye glitters. “The idea came to me much sooner, but I didn’t understand it until yesterday.” He twists the round object, a definite *click* ringing out.

The night sky above ripples. Stars rearrange themselves in sweeping arcs until a pattern emerges—one that dawns on Mydei immediately.

It is his and Phainon’s constellation. The one that burst into existence when they made love until their divinities resonated with perfect attunement. Sharp lines braided with sinuous curves, as if Kephale and Nikador’s insignias had entwined and quickened into something completely new.

Never has Mydei seen it so close, so clearly rendered outside of the Vortex of Genesis. It can only be seen on moonless nights in Okhema, though he’s always been aware of its presence, constant as sunlight or the brush of an easy breeze.

“Approximately one standard day into Era Nova,” Anaxa says in the cadence of a lecture, “the Express alerted me to the appearance of a new constellation in Amphoreus’ astral system. It had the Station’s scholars in quite a frenzy. The stars that make up a constellation usually have no association with one another, they told me. The patterns we see are simply tricks of perspective. But this one?” Anaxa huffs, and it sounds somewhat impressed. “This one came into existence as one entity. The first of its kind.”

Mydei swallows dryly. He and Phainon had marveled at the sight of it, panting and sated and entangled on a bed of feathers. To him, it had been just a happy coincidence—a timely symbol of their victory, of their reunion, of binding themselves as husbands.

“The Station and other groups tried to lay claim to it,” Anaxa continues, almost scornfully. “Perhaps to study it further, or for the bragging rights of ownership. They chose to not follow through after I visited. A wise choice, in my opinion.”

Mydei searches through his memories, quickly recalling the first and only time Anaxa was requested to go to the Station. “You two came home early. Phainon said you were banned from going back ever again.”

Anaxa waves his hand flippantly. “As if they can stop me. But no matter. I made my point clear enough.”

“You protected the constellation,” Mydei realizes. “That’s—that matters.”

Anaxa’s piercing look relaxes just enough to reveal the care underneath. “I knew it was connected to you two. What I didn’t know was what it might mean. Until yesterday.”

Mydei puts the pieces together. “The debate?”

“A rather uproarious spectacle,” Anaxa says, sounding oddly similar to Aglaea. “But even such chatter can reveal some fascinating theories. To will the transformation of Worldbearing from an epithet to an ability—now that is something else, indeed. And there is already some evidence to support it.”

Anaxa tips his head back. Mydei follows suit, drinking in the bright lines of the constellation etched across the heavens, as much a mark of defiance as of love. Heat floods his body, his *thymós* alight in the face of revelation, the implications of it. His and Phainon’s stars sparkle at him, as if in greeting.

“Isn’t it ironic?” Anaxa says at last. “You both have walked the path of Destruction, and yet you are also capable of the miracle of creation.”

Creation. That is what their constellation is. Not just a symbol, not mere coincidence. It is something born into the Cosmos itself. A product of their joining.

Mydei works his jaw. “I thought you didn’t believe in miracles,” he says, wrung out, braced with anticipation.

“I may be known for blasphemy,” Anaxa says, darkly amused, “but miracles?” His lips quirk. “Perhaps what we call a miracle is simply the product of humanity’s outrageous will pushing itself against impossible odds.”

Era Nova. Their survival. Bonds shattered and reforged stronger each cycle. The dawn-drenched mornings, the soft pillowed evenings. Phainon’s braid, clasped in gold, with his divinity entwined with Mydei’s forever. The stars they willed into being simply because they loved each other so.

Anaxa walks closer until they’re shoulder to shoulder. Mydei looks at Anaxa helplessly.

“Do you think—Phainon would want to—”

“That is a question best posed to him,” Anaxa cuts in gently. “One I suspect you will ask once he returns.” His gaze is steady, stern but not unkind. “But are you prepared for the consequences if he says yes?”

Mydei’s reply cracks with a half laugh. “Were you prepared when you defended our constellation and got banned from the Station?”

Anaxa rolls his shoulders. “Naturally. I would do it again with ease. But at the end of the day, it is a constellation.” He pauses, tone sobering. “A child, however—a child of a Lord Ravager and a demigod? That is another matter entirely.”

“Phainon isn’t a Lord Ravager anymore,” Mydei protests.

“By choice alone,” Anaxa counters. “Do you really that would dissuade others? From taking an interest in children born from two beings who’ve held Nanook’s attention? Phainon already draws the eyes of the Cosmos just by existing.”

Mydei stiffens. White-hot rage slices through the fog in his head like a lance, clearing it of any doubts and hesitations. His divine powers cannot rival Phainon’s—none of the Heirs’ can—but clarity sears a vow all the same: no person, no sovereign, no lofty god in the Cosmos will ever lay a finger on his husband and their children.

Their children. *Strife*. The thought is both blade and balm. He could choke on it—the tidal surge beating against his ribs, murmuring of names to be given and kisses bestowed on tiny starry brows.

“Calm yourself,” Anaxa says. The glow of Mydei’s tattoos spill across his face in fierce scarlet shadows. “You are not alone, Mydei. Should danger come, you and Phainon will have an entire world at your backs.”

Aglaea must already know. Castorice and the Trailblazers, too. Hyacine and Tribios won’t be far behind. Cifera either would have guessed from the start, or will quickly take it in stride once she learns of it. The citizens—surely some of the citizens already know, as well, if their enthusiasm in the baths is of any indication. It’s laughable, how Mydei and Phainon may very well be the last to figure it out.

“Thank you,” Mydei says. “Truly, Anaxagoras. Thank you.”

Anaxa shrugs. He twists the round object again. The star-scattered projection dissolves into a honey-gold morning. Clouds like spun sugar drift across a bright blue blanket. Sunlight beams down on them, warm as a blessing.

“Mydei! Anaxa!” Stelle’s voice echoes from the entrance. She’s jogging over and waving her arms, a smile stretching ear to ear. “Oh thank goodness you’re both in one piece—*holy shit what happened to the floor*—anyway, Phainon and Tribios are back!”

“Thanks is not necessary,” Anaxa muses. “But appreciated nonetheless. Off with you now. You still have a long day ahead.”

The Vortex of Genesis swirls around Mydei as he steps onto polished stone, only one goal in mind.

“He had a pretty rough time, De,” Tribios had said when Mydei and Stelle greeted her, alone, in Okhema. “Yesterday was weird but this morning… The visit was so different compared to before. He probably needs some time to think.”

“Go,” Stelle urged, pressing a comforting hand to Mydei’s arm. “Go to him.”

Mydei went without hesitation.

Just like most of the loopholes in Amphoreus’ original code, the Vortex of Genesis has been sealed off to all but the Chrysos Heirs and the Trailblazers. It now serves as a place of privacy, a liminal space where galaxies within Amphoreus’ astral system spiral above and around in real time.

Mydei hasn’t been here since he and Phainon exchanged their vows, that very first time.

The circular platform soaks beneath the light of a distant supernova. Stars swim around in a thousand kaleidoscopic colors, and the distant crash of waves against ancient stone reverberates through the endless space.

And there he is.

Phainon, perched on the edge of the platform, back to Mydei. His wings have torn through his robes, arching over the floor in ice-gold against midnight-black. Afterimages of a halo flicker around his head, though its light can’t compare to the burning brilliance of the mark of the sun.

Mydei comes closer, letting his footsteps fall naturally. He can see Phainon flinch before slowly turning. His blue eyes are almost too bright, shaded with a tint of yellow. His *rhimágmata* courses between shades of red and gold. He looks exhausted and lovely and lost.

Mydei says nothing, though his *thymós* roars at him to close the distance, to sweep Phainon into a crushing embrace, to soothe and settle him in the circle of Mydei’s arms.

Every ounce of his will struggles to be still, to let Phainon make the first delicate move.

Phainon swallows audibly. Then he slowly extends a hand toward Mydei, the other curled over the edge of the platform as if to brace himself.

And Mydei is sinking to his knees beside him, slipping his arms around Phainon and pulling him close, closer still, until Phainon settles atop him and Mydei buries his face into his neck, nearly crumpling with the familiar scent of olive resin and fire. *Equal, husband, you’re home*. *You’re home*.

“Mydei,” Phainon whispers, clinging just as fiercely. His wings sweep across the floor to encase them in a protective cocoon. He tucks Mydei’s head under his chin and presses his nose to the crown of Mydei’s head. He’s so warm. Warmer than usual. “Mydei.”

“You’re back,” Mydei says, like a prayer, like a promise fulfilled. “Though I thought I’d be saying that in our rooms and not on the floor here.”

Phainon laughs, a short and stuffy thing. “I couldn’t make it there in time. Forgive the spontaneity. Should I save the ‘I’m home’ for when we get back?”

“Shut up and come here,” Mydei demands.

“I’m already here!” But Phainon wiggles closer until there’s no place they’re not touching. Like this, Mydei swears he can feel their hearts thump against each other. Phainon’s wings block out the lights and sounds of the Vortex, and it’s them. Just them.

The ache in Mydei’s chest finally, blessedly, relaxes and reaches out to its partner.

Their divinities resonate in tandem. Pressure gives way to freedom—to the rapture of subsumption, of two souls dancing and meeting in the middle, heartbreaking for the distance that once divided them and healing in the very act of being together again.

We could make another constellation, Mydei thinks wildly, and smothers a chuckle in Phainon’s skin at his own absurdity.

“What’s so funny?” Phainon asks, tugging at his braid. “Did I miss the punchline to something?”

“There are so many things you’ve missed,” Mydei says, raw.

“Looks like we both had a time of it,” Phainon says, the words trembling at the end. Mydei catches the break and shifts.

“Wait, don’t move,” Phainon insists, pressing Mydei’s head down when he tries to lift himself.

“Why not? Let me see your face.”

Phainon says thickly, “Nuh-uh, not so fast.”

“Are you crying?”

“No. Your hair got in my nose, that’s all.”

“Let me remedy that.” Mydei nips Phainon’s neck, grazing his teeth over the sensitive skin.

Phainon grunts in surprise, but maintains his hold. “Nice try, but that only worked the first time—Mydei!” he yips when Mydei sinks his teeth into muscle. Phainon’s grip loosens just enough for Mydei to roll them over, to see Phainon’s face in full.

“Rascal,” Phainon accuses. His eyes are glazed with stubbornly unshed tears. A dash of bright pink covers his nose. He sniffles again. “Happy? Now you have to look at me like this. You only have yourself to blame.”

“Ridiculous.” Mydei cups his face, tracing the edges of one *rhimágmata* under Phainon’s eye. “What is to blame? I only see my husband looking like a puppy that’s been left out in the rain.”

Phainon’s wings flutter, the pinions gliding over Mydei’s back. “Well your husband has had a very long day, so excuse him for not looking his best.”

Mydei scoffs. “Do you think I concern myself with how you look? I’ve kissed you covered in titankin guts and blood with no complaint, so spare me your self-flagellation.”

Phainon glares weakly and hooks his hands over the nape of Mydei’s neck. “You know, this wasn’t the romantic homecoming I imagined.”

“Had you stayed with Tribios in Okhema like you usually do, I would have had no trouble sweeping you off your feet and bringing you back to our rooms for a proper reunion.” Mydei leans down and noses along Phainon’s cheek, basking in his scent, his heat.

Phainon exhales shakily and nuzzles back, albeit slow and tired. His body is a livewire of tension. Divine power hums under his skin, tempered, but still electric.

It’s one of those times, then. Mydei sets his mind. He presses gentle, deliberate touches to Phainon’s face, neck, and collarbones. He kisses the bite he made, laving over the tender mark with his tongue. His hands roam over Phainon’s body, working out the tough knots, just as much soothing his husband as he is himself.

Phainon’s breath hitches, an airy sigh slipping his lips. Gradually, he relaxes, sinking into Mydei’s arms. His brow smoothes out, and his grip on Mydei’s nape gentles as his eyes close. “Mmm. Mydei…”

Mydei shushes him, planting a trail of kisses along his jawline. When he reaches the edge of Phainon's mouth, he stops and waits.

Phainon whines, a familiar, intoxicating sound, and tilts his head to connect their lips. It’s a tender kiss. A sweet little peck, just like the ones he gives Mydei every morning.

A million butterflies couldn’t match the burst of emotion in Mydei’s chest. He tips his chin and pecks back, not deepening the kiss but prolonging it, savoring it. This, too, feels like home. Phainon’s breath warm on his skin. His legs wrapped around Mydei’s hips. A gust of cool, sea-tinged air as his wings unfurl and finally rest, splayed out around him.

Phainon pulls back, smiling. “I’m home,” he says, as sweet as his kisses.

“Welcome home.” Mydei cups the back of his head, combing through loose and wavy hair where Phainon’s twin plaits have come undone. Only one messy braid still remains, secured with the gold clasp. He tugs it lightly. “This wasn’t like this when you left.”

“I didn’t mean for your hard work to go to waste.” Phainon sighs. “It was fine until this morning.”

“During which…”

Phainon groans. “Can we go back to kissing?”

Mydei tugs the braid again. “Come on. Up.”

Phainon whines and grumbles the whole time, but he lets Mydei maneuver them into a sitting position, still in Mydei’s lap with his arms draped over his shoulders.

Mydei squeezes Phainon's hips and peers up at his face. "Still holding out on me? I thought my Deliverer never backs down from a challenge."

"Hmph," Phainon sniffs. His lips scrunch up into a pout. Mydei bites back a grin.

"What's this—a sulk? Has my husband been so bested by a bad morning that he can't tell me what troubles him?"

"Nothing bested me," Phainon says immediately. "I held my own at the Station. Tribios can vouch for me!"

"You make it sound like you were in a fight," Mydei says. "What happened to just meeting with Madam Herta? You mentioned in your message that strange things happened during the visit."

Phainon nods vigorously. "That's the thing! When Tribios and I got to the Express yesterday, the crew was already there. Usually, it's Himeko or Welt who receives us, but everyone was there—even Pom-Pom! Did you know Pom-Pom scolded me for not taking care of myself enough? What did they even mean by that?"

"Breathe," Mydei reminds him, logging every detail.

Phainon does rather impatiently and carries on. "Then Welt said all of them would be coming with us to the Station, and Sunday would be accompanying me in the visit to ward off disharmonious energies."

It's how Phainon mentioned it before. "What did he mean by that?"

"Who knows," Phainon says, waving his hands. "Maybe remnants of Era Nova's backlash? Anyway, when we got to the Station, almost a hundred of their scholars were waiting for us. Caelus distracted them, and Sunday got us to Madam Herta."

Mydei tenses. After the first and only disastrous attempt to study their powers and responses in the Simulated Universe, both sides compromised to keep academic inquiries more akin to personal interviews. Herta's line of questioning followed a standard script for almost every Heir. For the sake of civility as well as safety.

"When I met with Madam Herta," Phainon stops. He looks down, eyes lidded. In a move that makes Mydei's heart trip over itself, Phainon moves his hands to cup his lower belly.

"She kept looking here, and asking if there was anything different with my body since last time," Phainon says. "Any patterns I've noticed. Fatigue, nausea, changes with my appetite or sleep."

Mydei can't stop himself. "What did you say?"

Phainon gives a little laugh. "It sounds odd, but I asked if she thought I was pregnant." He smiles crookedly at Mydei. "Those are the usual symptoms. But I was just joking. It's plain silly, right?"

He makes it sound so simple. So unaffected. Mydei stares up at him, flummoxed. He should say something. Should chuckle or scoff at such supposed nonsense.

But he knows better. Knows more. *Wants* more.

At each passing second, Phainon's cheer fades, replaced by a stunned expression.

"Mydei?" he says, almost disbelieving, starting to squirm on Mydei's lap. "You don't… there's no way you think I'm preg—"

It's too much. Mydei pins him down with firm hands and says, low and urgent, "Listen—the people think you can bear a child."

Phainon blinks at him. Mydei waits for him to sputter, to laugh. To refute him and call the very notion ridiculous, and launch into an hours-long exposition on the sheer absurdity of such a statement.

His husband does none of that.

"Oh," Phainon says instead. His hands have stilled over his abdomen.

"It's a long story," Mydei starts, rubbing Phainon's back as he quickly tries to explain, "Stelle and Cas found a book and they needed help translating it, but it led into a whole debate in the baths and—"

"Do you think I can?" Phainon interrupts, barely louder than a whisper.

Mydei chokes. "What?"

Time stretches. Phainon's throat works. His gaze flickers with countless unreadable thoughts. "Do you think I can bear a child?"

Mydei's words crumble in his mouth. His heart pounds, riotous. Phainon slowly leans in. He takes Mydei's limp hands and places them on his belly, cupping them like he did before.

Like they are both holding something precious.

Behind Phainon's head, their constellation shines radiant and proud.

Phainon's eyes blaze, vulnerable, yet also daring as he says, "Mydei, would you want me to?"

Chapter End Notes

See you all on the next chapter! *runs*

my twt!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> *For the Cryptogenists, now called the Nousporists, those few who dare to push beyond the limits of academic study, 'creation' is a reflection of that mysterious composition they call a 'soul'.*
>
> *Few words can describe the difficulties, then, in reconciling these schools of thought to prove—or disprove—that which remains one of Kephale's most mysterious divine attributes.*

Chapter Notes

> Let's finish this journey together!
>
> ▶ **author's notes/content warnings**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To wish, despite everything—it is a feeling Mydei has long known.

In his earliest memories, it had been of the most innocent, fervent kind. The frantic gasps of a child tossed about by dark waves in the Sea of Souls. *Help me*. *Save me*. *Someone, anyone*. Each of his deaths had been bracketed by those prayers.

And when each of his deaths were rejected by Thanatos, the first breaths he took were to start them all over again—*someone*, *anyone*.

Prayers unanswered until the detachment found him, and the feeling took root, growing fast on its new foundation. His comrades became his shield and blanket as they sang and feasted under the vastness of stars.

Those were halcyon days, when the evernight veil, the black tide, the weight of the crown and throne—all of it became far less intimidating when he knew he was no longer alone.

And when the singing and feasting were done, he'd curl up in the protective middle of his closest friends and let the feeling lull him to sleep as he prayed, *let me keep this*. *Let me stay with them*. *Let us fight together forever*.

Then he lost them. One by one, and the ache in his heart became almost too much to bear. And still the legacy of his people loomed high above. A gilded legacy he chose to set aside,

instead taking them away from their ancestral home to the one place that fate had left as his last option.

It was there, before Okhema's gates, that the feeling took on the shape of something like desire.

Desire, when Phainon of Aedes Elysiae met his eyes across the battlefield and smiled. It was an imperfect smile that showed too much teeth, crooked on one side. Smeared with golden blood, though Mydei couldn't tell whether it was the man's or his own.

An imperfect smile, cracking past the Deliverer's facade as he grinned at Mydei on the dawn of the tenth day and raised his sword again. He smiled like that at Mydei alone, and no one else.

I want you to always smile like that. A terrible thing for a future king to demand, even in the privacy of his own mind, of a man he barely knew and could ask nothing of.

I want you to always smile at me. Even more selfish a wish. Unbecoming of a Crown Prince; moreso to ask it of the one person blessed and burdened to bring Amphoreus to the new dawn.

Phainon of Aedes Elysiae was not his to keep.

So Mydei had not asked. Had not made it a possibility to himself. He tampered down the wave of emotion whenever Phainon spoke with him, puzzled him, infuriated him, challenged him, won and lost against him and still had the audacity to smile regardless of the outcome.

As if victory and defeat were the same thing to him. Or rather, victory or defeat was not the point.

It would have been easier, or far less complicated, if Phainon did not inspire desire in Mydei as easily as breathing.

I want to know more about your home and your people. Phainon's gaze, cast far over the horizon when he thought no one was looking. Somewhere to a place that Mydei could not find on any map, that Phainon held closer to his heart than anything else.

I want to help shoulder your worries and troubles. A particularly difficult Council meeting that made golden threads tremble in outrage and Phainon's jaw clench for days afterward, unwilling to speak of it despite Mydei waiting for him.

I want you to take care of yourself for once, damn it. As the black tide encroached, and their missions became more dangerous, yet still shouldered with a smile far too bright, too out of place with the golden blood spilled to carry them out.

"I want you," Mydei did not say.

He did not say it even when it became natural for them to step into place beside each other as the Flame-Chase hurtled toward its destiny. Even when the years in Phainon's company made Mydei believe in a future where the end of the west wind will greet them kindly.

“I want you at my side, always,” he kept behind gritted teeth, in the palms of his fists.

Such a wish stood antithesis to the Flame-Chase to which Phainon was so devoted. He could not do it—to insist upon such selfishness when Strife was Mydei's burden to bear. He would not make Phainon lose a husband when duty would eventually call Mydei to arms.

Perhaps, in the *tomorrow* that was promised, they wouldn’t have reason to lose each other at all.

Then the Trailblazers came, and everything moved so fast, and all the things Mydei wanted were forged into stepping stones for the new dawn.

He was glad for it, would make the sacrifice again and again without regret.

Because the new dawn gave them Era Nova, and the truth of their world, and the universe unfolding like an endless map to be charted.

It gave him Phainon.

Phainon, falling into his arms. Phainon, radiant and divine as the fated cycles shattered like crystal rain around them. In the light of that first new morning, he was smiling fearless and free and everything Mydei ever wanted for him.

Ethereal, for whom the Miracle of Genesis bloomed and bore Amphoreus to the Cosmos.

“Found you,” Phainon had said.

At that moment, Mydei *wanted*, more than anything. More the five great virtues. More the meaning of the word itself. More than code, and what was written in the stars for him.

“Keep me,” Mydei said. “Stay with me.”

And Phainon—

—Phainon met him in the middle, as he always did, as Mydei always wished for him to.

So, Mydei thought he knew what it meant to wish, despite everything. Despite the odds. Because of them. It was his blessing to have all its meanings be subsumed into his husband, one he guards fiercely and proud for it.

But as Phainon looks at him now, star-drenched and expectant, Mydei realizes that he knew little of the feeling, after all. That there can be so much more to it than he allowed himself to hope for.

Would you want me to?

The words seem to echo around them, this place that was the cradle of their world.

It could be the cradle of something else, if.

If—

Phainon presses Mydei's palms firmly on his abdomen. His eyes shimmer in the lights of a thousand galaxies.

A thousand galaxies could not compare to the multitude of wishes that Mydei barely holds himself back from making.

“My, my,” Phainon husks. “What's this? Has my husband been so bested by a simple question that he can't even look at me?”

He wanted to talk to Phainon about this, did he not? Longed for when they would reunite, so they could speak on the matter together.

But when faced with Phainon being the one to bring it up—

Any explanation, any excuse suddenly seems so paltry.

Phainon cups his cheek. Mydei leans into the touch, shuts his eyes at the roughness of Phainon's palm.

“You don't know what you ask.”

“Oh? I think I was quite clear.” Phainon shifts. The hard panes of his abdomen flex. Could they really soften and give way, to make room for—“Mydei,” Phainon says above the shell of his ear, “Would you want me to bear a child, if I could?”

Mydei's hands seize, clamping down on Phainon's waist. *I want I want I want—*

Phainon chuckles, a tad shaky, and says, “How does the saying go? Actions speak louder than words?”

Of course they do. Mydei knows that better than anyone. He tips his head and buries his face in Phainon's chest, breathing in his scent. Long fingers rake through his hair, tug at his braid.

Phainon's heartbeat is a steady pitter-patter, faster than usual.

Ah. So Mydei isn't the only one affected. There is something else his husband is not saying. Something he is covering up by redirecting attention to Mydei.

Luckily, Mydei knows him well enough to know how to play along.

“Would, could,” he says, sharpening his focus. “Why do you speak in hypotheticals?”

Phainon noses along his temple. “It might be because I'm working with a hypothetical situation.”

“Being, if you could get *pregnant*.” He chooses the word deliberately.

Phainon's pulse jumps. Mydei is attuned to it, a lion on the hunt.

“Well,” Phainon says, drawing it out. “If someone as smart as a Genius thought I could, don't you think it's interesting to talk about?”

“So she *did* think you could,” confirms Mydei, resting his chin on Phainon's clavicle. “You never mentioned what her response was after *you* brought the possibility up to her.”

Phainon's cheeks turn rosy. “I think it’s a logical deduction based on the questions she asked me.”

“The symptoms she mentioned could have been because of anything else,” Mydei points out. “Your *rhimágmata.* Kephale's divinity.” Their bodies may have been reforged anew in Era Nova, but Phainon's body still carries the weight of millions of cycles. He closes in. “Why did you think of pregnancy first?”

Phainon's mouth opens, but nothing comes out.

Mydei meets his eyes and challenges, “Is it because you wanted it to be an option?”

“Mydei,” Phainon says weakly.

There it is, so close. Mydei pushes on. His own heartbeat thunders in his ears. “Did you want to hear someone else say it before you brought it up to me?”

Phainon's pupils are blown wide. His hands turn hot on Mydei's shoulders. The mark of the sun flashes. A twitch of his wings is Mydei's only warning before he feels Phainon tense, like a bird about to take flight.

“No you don't,” he growls, and pitches them forward. Phainon lands on his back with a gasp. Mydei arches over him, clamping his thighs tight around Phainon's hips. Another push and a smooth slide, and he pins Phainon’s flailing hands beside his head.

“Going somewhere, husband?” he drawls.

Phainon tries to buck him off, but Mydei rides the movement easily. Phainon hisses, flushed, “What are you doing?”

“Trying to have a conversation,” he replies. “Which was going well until you tried to escape.”

“I didn't—!”

He raises a brow. Phainon purses his lips and looks away.

A win in Mydei's favor. Mydei lets him pout, then eases himself down to the side. He pulls Phainon over so they're facing each other. Phainon keeps his eyes somewhere below Mydei's chin.

Mydei drinks him in: the furrowed set of his brows, the way he nibbles his bottom lip, how his throat works and his fingers squeeze Mydei's again and again as if trying to ground himself in the motion.

He is so painfully lovely against the backdrop of stars.

It's absurd, how quickly Mydei is convinced to break the silence first.

“Let us speak candidly," he says, slow so as to not spook him again.

Phainon nods, eyes still averted.

Mydei presses gently, “Is it possible for you to carry a child?”

Phainon's long lashes flutter. When he finally answers, he is so quiet that Mydei has to strain to hear, “I think it’s possible.”

Mydei takes the end of Phainon's braid, thumbing it to steady his shaking fingers. “How?”

Phainon watches his fingers. “Between divinity and Destruction, our bodies are new. I have my wings. You can still summon your *thymós*. Anything is possible, at this point.”

Mydei's eyes flick down. Phainon pinches the skin of his palm and whisper-shouts, “Mydei! Nothing's changed there! It's more of intuition. A feeling. I think I could, if I wanted.”

Inside Mydei, something clicks into place, like a key unlocking a door. It swings open, but he can't take a step forward. Not yet. Not without Phainon. “Would you?” he asks.

Phainon shivers all over. He shuffles closer and presses his forehead into Mydei's shoulder.

“Won’t it be dangerous?” Phainon says. The words flow out of him faster now. “Carrying a child—I don't know how my body will handle it. And there's still so much we have to do for Okhema. For Amphoreus. Is now the right time?”

Mydei turns the non-answer over in his mind, parsing through what went unspoken. “Let me rephrase. Would you *want to*, if you could?”

Phainon burrows deeper into the meat of Mydei's shoulder, still clinging to his hand.

“Phainon?”

Phainon tenses. Mydei can see the thoughts tumbling over themselves in his husband's head. He understands it—the hesitance to have someone perceive him so deeply, because hope can be as strong as steel and as easily snuffed out as a candle flame.

Mydei lifts himself up on an elbow and leans over Phainon, brushing away the hair covering his ear.

“Won't you tell me,” he says, tender at how Phainon shudders in anticipation, “Khaslana?”

My soul knows yours, there is nothing to hide from me.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon whispers. “You’re playing dirty. You can't just use my name like that.”

“I consider it necessary for this circumstance,” he tells him. “Otherwise you'll never tell me what’s on your mind.”

Phainon makes a low, almost chagrined sound before muttering, “That's because it depends.”

“Depends on what?”

“Depends on if you want it, also. A child.”

Blue eyes peer up at him through long lashes, searching. Bright in their clarity. Time yields, and the world suspends in vibrant starry hues.

Also, Phainon said.

Also, meaning, *you are not alone*.

Also, because *I, too, wish for—*

Mydei releases Phainon's hand and cups his face, tipping it up to look at him fully.

“I want them to have your eyes.” He touches the slack line of Phainon's mouth. “And your smile.”

Phainon seems to tremble as he reaches for Mydei. “That's funny,” he says, smiling crookedly, widely. “I was just thinking the same thing.”

Only Phainon could make it so easy for Mydei to believe in the impossible. To make it come true.

“I want two,” he bursts out. Phainon's hands are hot, roaming over his eager body. Lips follow and chase Mydei's honesty, which he gives without restraint. “Or three—or four, if you want. If we can.”

He can be greedy this time, can’t he? Can be selfish in front of his husband, and know he won’t be turned away or shamed for such a wish? Can bare his neck, reveal his vulnerable underbelly, lay his desires before Phainon and not be afraid, for he knows they will be reciprocated in full?

Phainon laughs in answer. The Vortex shimmers with it, coming to life in a bloom of colors as if celebrating. This world loves him just as much as Mydei loves him.

“We can,” Phainon says, thick with emotion. “Mydei, we can.”

Later, much later, Mydei traces the halo on Phainon's sternum with his lips and murmurs, “When?”

Phainon plays with the ends of his hair, sifting through the sweaty strands with gentle fingers. “There were mentions of it in the other cycles,” he says sleepily, “but only as a joke. The title Worldbearing lends itself to it, doesn't it?”

Mydei snorts, recalling the debacle in the baths. “So I've learned.”

Phainon hums. “I like it. Taking care of the little ones in Okhema. The Kremnoan children, too. They remind me of the kids back in Aedes Elysiae.”

Mydei drops a kiss on the mark of the sun.

Phainon says wistfully, “I saw how you were with them, back in Okhema. You taught them, trained and played with them. So fair and kind. I always thought you would be a good parent, like your mother.”

Now that. That makes Mydei's chest squeeze tight. He has never sought validation for the way he tried to not be like Eurypon after Strife's madness took him. To be more like Gorgo, in what little ways he could.

Hearing it from Phainon feels like he’s seen in a new light, seen to the core of him.

“You would be a good parent, too,” Mydei says. Even Destruction could not remove love from Phainon's very being. “But you would be far less strict with them, I'd wager.”

“Ah,” Phainon sighs, sounding content. “As if we both won't spoil them rotten.”

Mydei is dozing when Phainon, tucked into his side and still breathing heavily from their last bout, says, “I truly didn't think about it until you brought me that basket from Demetria. I thought you knew those herbs are usually given to expecting or nursing mothers.”

Mydei groans, remembering what Phainon told him about the cremni pear. *Maternal origin*, he himself had said. The answer was there from the start. Had Demetria already suspected it from that moment? Truly, speculation traveled quickly among Okhema's citizenry.

He musters the strength to tell Phainon everything: about the Trailblazers, the baths, the misunderstandings. By the end of it, Phainon is laughing so hard that tears bud at the corners of his eyes.

“It’s good to know the people care,” Phainon wheezes. “A fight in the baths! Did someone really throw a sandal? An entire fruit platter? What face did Krateros make, again?”

“Do not make me repeat the story, Deliverer.”

Phainon shakes. “Someone said you were infertile,” he howls before breaking down in another fit of laughter.

Mydei scowls and rolls them over. “I'll show you infertile—!”

After, he points to their constellation. “That one is ours.”

“Huh?” Phainon slurs, boneless in the afterglow. Heat radiates from him as he props himself up, following Mydei's finger. “What is?”

Mydei, momentarily distracted by the slick stretch of Phainon's body, gives himself a shake and says, “The constellation. We made it.” He can't help but puff his chest. “It's our creation. Some of the people were right.” Protective instinct wells. “We’ll have to discuss more counter-measures against people claiming it as their own.”

“What are you talking about?” Phainon says, puzzled. He tilts his head. The fine line of his neck becomes very appealing.

Mydei does not give up (there is no word for giving up in the Kremnoan language) but he does set the matter aside in favor of a more pressing task.

“Ask Anaxagoras when we get back,” he says instead, sliding a hand down Phainon’s flank.

“What does Professor Anaxa have to do with… *Ah*, Mydei, again? I can't—“

“You can,” Mydei says, and proceeds to smugly, thoroughly prove his point.

“Mydei.”

“Mm.”

“Four, really?”

“Too many?”

“We don't even know if we can handle one.”

“What if it's twins?”

“Twins! How ambitious, husband mine. You truly are thinking ahead. I suppose there's little we can do, if it's twins.”

“Then, what if it's triplets?”

“Now you're pushing it. How am I supposed to carry triplets?”

“… with practice?”

“Hahaha, is this still a hypothetical situation?”

“You said anything is possible.”

“Possible, yes. Feasible is another thing. The logistics of it…”

“Children enjoy being around each other, Deliverer. It will be good for them to be playmates and grow together.”

“Yes, but can you imagine raising two or three at the same time? Or me carrying two or three at once? How will I be able to move like that?”

“…”

“Mydei? Why are you looking at me like that? Hey, Mydei, what are you—*whoa*—!”

Later on:

“You brute, my back hurts.”

“My apologies.”

“Could you be any more blasé? There was not a single hint of sincerity in that sentence.”

“Nor was there any hint of regret in yours.”

“*Hah*. You'll have to do more than that to make me regret anything.”

“If you're issuing another challenge, I'd be happy to oblige.”

“…”

“That’s what I thought.”

“So what happened after?”

Phainon, drawing lazy, nonsensical shapes through the fresh sweat on Mydei's pectorals, hums questioningly.

“At the Station. After meeting with Herta.” He should have asked sooner about what led Phainon to be in such a state upon coming home, but Phainon doesn't seem to take offense at the delay.

“She ended the session early,” he explains. “Caelus and Sunday snuck me and Tribios out to explore the lower decks. It was quite fun. We should go there sometime, when we’re allowed on the Station together. We fell asleep watching the stars.”

“On the floor?”

Phainon chuckles. “Mr. Yang brought sleeping bags and blankets and kept guard over us. Sunday fell asleep right away. Caelus kept giggling about that for some reason.”

“Hm.” Mydei had seen the Express's Welt Yang in action when the Battle for Amphoreus was raging. He was experienced and steady. Anyone would rest easy with him around.

Mydei will have to send him a token of thanks later, for the protection given over Tribios and his husband.

“Then in the morning?” he prompted.

Phainon clicks his tongue. “We found out a lot of new people were visiting the Station. Scholars and the like. Most of them weren't Madam Herta's. I think they came from other planets.” He drops his head in the crook of Mydei’s neck. “They kept mentioning 'my condition', asking me about it. I was fine the first few times but—” he cuts himself off.

“It became overwhelming,” Mydei fills in.

He can easily imagine it: the suffocating press of dozens of strangers around Phainon and Tribios, in a place far from the familiarity of Amphoreus; how his husband's instincts to protect would rise and ultimately conflict with his desire to maintain peace with others, stranger or not.

“It got so loud,” Phainon confesses. “I couldn’t hear myself think, and I felt like my body was burning up. No one would speak plainly. I thought they meant the *rhimágmata*. I could never have known they meant pregnancy, of all things!”

No wonder he was so upset. Mydei runs a reassuring hand down his back. “There were so many of them," Phainon sighs. “Then Tribios and Caelus nearly got separated from us, and, well. It was a good thing the other Nameless were there to intervene. I may have said some choice words, though.”

“Good,” says Mydei viciously. He's more than indulgent of Phainon defending his boundaries. “Choice words are the least they deserve.”

Phainon laughs, clearly scandalized and pleased in equal measure. “Ah, Mydei. Maybe it was a good thing for them you weren't there. What if your crystals broke the Station a second time?”

“Like the first time, I will take responsibility but I refuse to be blamed for it,” Mydei tells him. “That's how I am when I have someone precious to protect.”

The few poets of Castrum Kremnos would have shaken their heads, mortified. But it’s worth it, to have Mydei's only equal kiss him passionately, wholly, freely.

“We should probably head back,” Phainon mumbles into their makeshift bed of capes and clothes which desperately need a good wash. His wings have been recalled, leaving the broad expanse of his back tantalizingly bare. “It's been a few days, hasn't it?”

“Three, not counting today.” Mydei stretches and grunts with satisfaction as his joints pop, leaving behind a languid satisfaction. Passion sated and contented for now.

“Three days,” Phainon repeats. He looks over his shoulder, grinning. “Do you think the others are worried?”

“No. I am here with you.” Mydei watches his husband stretch with an appreciative eye. His eyes linger on the curves of Phainon’s waist, his belly. He gives in, nipping the hip closest to him.

Phainon swats at him. A gust of wind would have more force. “Don't start what you can't finish,” he chides.

“Who can't finish,” mutters Mydei, but complies. They have put off returning for long enough. He does not dare to imagine the mountains of work waiting for them when they get back, courtesy of a vindictive Aglaea.

As is her right; he and Phainon are supposed to be helping her with the rebuilding, after all.

“We should bathe,” Phainon says, picking up his undershirt. “Let's go back to our rooms first? I want to see the chimeras.”

“They're probably with Cas.” When he and Phainon are away, the chimeras' first choice of a sitter is almost always Castorice. A stray memory prickles at the back of his mind. “By the way, do you think Beagle Coconut—”

“Hm?” Phainon moves to stand. He makes a soft, startled sound. Seems to freeze, as if his body has locked in place. He sways and tilts to the side.

Mydei rushes to catch him. “Phainon,” he says, horrified at the pale sheen that's come over Phainon. Scarlet crystals grow and sparkle on the ground.

“Mydei,” Phainon says, voice strange and confused. The mark of the sun pulses. “Something feels different.”

His hand moves to his stomach.

“Hyacine!” Mydei roars, stumbling into the Twilight Courtyard. His head spins from the pressure of Space Anchor travel but he refuses to stop and rest.

Hyacine and Stelle jump up. A delicate tea set on the table between them rattles. At Hyacine's feet, Little Ica lets out a sharp *doot-doot*. It's early morning, and the bustling courtyard comes to a standstill. Dozens of widened eyes turn to him.

Mydei can only imagine the sight he must make: haphazardly dressed with no gauntlets, hair mussed and undone; carrying a sweating and shivering Phainon wrapped up in their capes.

Stelle curses and rushes over to them, teleslate already in hand. Hyacine starts giving out orders. The courtyard snaps into action, attendants full-on sprinting to carry them out.

“Is he injured?” Stelle asks, urgent.

“He fell over in the Vortex.” He feels ice-cold and blazing hot, as if his body can't decide how to react to his husband rendered so weak in his arms. “We were just about to return. He was —I don’t—”

“Mydei,” Hyacine says calmly. He blinks at her, heart threatening to break out from his ribcage.

“I don't know what happened,” he says, throat clogged with simmering panic when Phainon groans in his arms. Little Ica sniffs at Phainon, wings aflutter. Stelle looks like she's been punched.

Hyacine hides her worry well except for where the corners of her mouth pinch tight. “Let's bring him inside.”

Mydei follows at her heels to a small private room in a secluded hall. The curtains are drawn. Several attendants come in with baskets of cloths and jars of medicinal concoctions.

As Hyacine directs the attendants and Stelle taps a blur on her teleslate, Mydei carefully lays Phainon on the kline in the middle of the room.

“Mydei,” Phainon says, weary. His vigor has dissipated like smoke, pallor making the *rhimágmata* stand out more. He lifts a hand. Mydei catches it and presses his lips to the knuckles.

“I’m here,” he says. It makes Phainon smile. The tiniest sliver of relief cuts through the heavy, tight knot in Mydei's chest.

Before Era Nova, he and Phainon rarely incurred injuries serious enough to warrant a visit to the Twilight Courtyard. Golden blood has its boons, and Nikador and Kephale's divinities granted their own form of immunity against nearly all illnesses.

So when Phainon spasms and pitches over the other side of the bed, retching, Mydei is helpless to do anything but hold him.

“—alert the others as well,” Hyacine is saying somewhere behind him. She comes to Mydei's side. “Tell me everything,” she commands.

Mydei does. Hyacine is professional enough to wave off his stumbling explanations on the more intimate details. She raises her hands over Phainon's body, divine power flaring from her fingertips in rainbow colors.

Phainon cracks one eye open. “Hyacine?” he mumbles. “What's happening?”

Hyacine bites her lip. She glances at Mydei. “Is it okay if you can stand outside with Stelle for a moment? I have to do a full-body examination, and Little Ica and I need the space.”

The last thing he wants is to get in the way of her work. Still, letting go of his husband is a painful endeavor in more ways than one. He squeezes Phainon's hand, only mildly reassured when he squeezes back and sinks into the kline with a labored sigh.

“I got you,” Stelle chimes, and guides Mydei out to the hall.

Mydei does not realize he is sitting and staring at the closed door until Stelle fills his sight. She squats in front of him.

“Hey.” She snaps her fingers lightly to get his attention. “Mydei, hey. It's going to be okay.”

“I have never seen him like that.” It comes out wounded.

“He'll be fine,” she says. “We'll make sure of it.” Her voice takes on the slightest reverb, a touch of the preternatural. She suddenly seems older, more mature.

Mydei knows a little of the Stellaron split between her and Caelus. How mighty and how dangerous it is. The divided views on how to handle its power. The twin Trailblazers are believed by many to be harbingers of cosmic ruin.

But he believes in them, in the indomitable willpower of the Nameless. More than anything, he trusts them. He sucks in a breath and nods, bracing his elbows on his knees.

“Do you think it's Destruction?” asks Stelle.

“If it is, it's a new effect.” Even at his weakest after Era Nova, Phainon never almost collapsed like he did today.

Stelle frowns. “I didn't feel any remnants on him. He looks like he's in the middle of a really bad cold. I got one, back on the Luofo. It was awful.”

“Let it be a cold, and nothing worse.” If anything, it is something Mydei can work with.

The minutes pass, slow as a slog through mud. No sound escapes the room. Stelle paces back and forth. After several turns, she sighs and sits with her legs crossed next to Mydei.

It reminds him of when she waited for him at the Grove. He pats down his pocket and is relieved to take out the braided grass.

“You still have it!” Stelle exclaims, cheery. She cocks her head. “Oh, um, it's a little squished.”

A little squished is putting it generously. The poor braid looks like it went through a Coreflame trial. It’s uneven, fraying and stretched, with one end bent awkwardly in the other direction.

“I'm sorry.”

Stelle shrugs. “You kept it. That's what matters. But geez, did you use it as a training dummy and give it a good pounding or something?”

Strife. Mydei resolutely does not meet her eyes. Clothes had not exactly come flying off the first few times in the Vortex. The braid was in his pocket the whole time.

Stelle covers her mouth. “Mydei. Dude. My good sir.”

“Say nothing.”

“That's why you and Phainon disappeared for three days!?”

“Why do you sound so surprised?” he demands, shoving the braid back into his pocket.

“I'm not! I'm just—I mean, if *that* little thing looked like that after three days—”

“Stelle!”

“Just sayin', no wonder Phainon looked so worn out—”

Mydei is both grateful and surprised when he hears a slew of voices at the end of the hall, followed by Caelus and Sunday striding into view.

“Cae!” Stelle runs to her twin, who catches her mid-run with a bemused expression. “Sitrep, sitrep. No, don't go near Mydei yet. Trust me.”

A more composed Sunday side-steps the twins. His wings flick as he places a hand over his heart and bows. “Mydeimos. Stelle sent word of Phainon's condition. I thought to accompany Caelus and provide aid.”

“Your support is welcomed,” Mydei says, Aglaea’s courtesy lessons kicking in as he tries to match the Halovian’s formal tone. “Is your Harmony like her powers?”

“In a way,” demurs Sunday. “I am able to sense certain dissonances in one’s energy and help dispel or ward against them.”

“Phainon told me that's what you did for him at the Station. You have my thanks.”

Sunday hesitates. His brow furrows. “About that, when we were there—”

“—you are!” Dan Heng says, skidding around the corner. He is breathing hard. “You two could have waited a little longer. March and Mr. Yang are on their way. Hello, Mydei. Stelle, why are you smiling like that?”

“The crew is coming here?” Mydei says, dumbfounded, at the same time Stelle cries, “At least give me a hello too, Dan Heng!”

“It was a unanimous decision,” replies Sunday, not distracted by Dan Heng’s “*Hey!*” as he’s dragged into the twins’ huddle. “Pom-Pom remains on the Express, and Himeko and Welt will swap every other hour until we can be sure of Phainon's condition.”

There is the rapid thudding of more footsteps, and the hall bursts with color and noise. The other Heirs pour into the space with Castorice leading at the front with Tribios and Cipher behind her. Upon seeing Mydei, she lights up and waves eagerly.

Anaxagoras steps out from behind her.

“*To the soul*,” he hisses. A gust of metallic wind and brilliant green light crackle over the impromptu reunion. Mydei finds himself frozen in place as Anaxa advances with a wicked gleam in his eye.

“Crown Prince, what did I say about consequences?”

“Professor Anaxa!”

“Holy shit!”

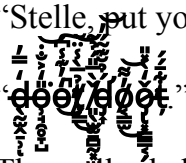
“Hahaha, where's the Goldweaver? Can you imagine the look on her face when she sees this —”

“Dan Heng, do something or Sunday's gonna end up a roast chicken—”

“Naxy, let De go!”

“Stelle, put your teleslate away and help me—”

“[illegible]”



The walls shake like the heavens descending in one fell swoop. There's a cacophony of shouts and gasps and curses in multiple languages. Powers and weapons are summoned in flashes of light and fluctuating temperatures. Caelus's lance somehow ends up in the ceiling.

As one, they turn toward the source of the eldritch sound.

Little Ica stares balefully from the open door.

“Thank you, Little Ica,” Hyacine says sweetly. She puts her hands on her hips. “All of you need to be quiet, please!” she scolds. “Professor, you *do* know that Phainon will be very upset if anything happens to Mydei. And Mr. Sunday, can you come with me? I need a second opinion.”

They stare at her, no one daring to speak first.

“Of course,” Sunday whispers. He slips into the room in haste.

Mydei, freed of Anaxa's sublimation, regains his balance. “How is he?” he rasps, feeling pinpricks all over. “Can I come in?”

“Not yet, but soon,” Hyacine says not unkindly, not answering either before following Sunday.

Little Ica stays outside the door, looking rather put-off. It is likely the only reason why Anaxa remains on the other side of the hall, arms crossed. Mydei tries very hard not to look in his direction and counts his blessings that Aglaea hasn't yet arrived.

“I thought,” Anaxa says severely, his voice projecting, “you two were going to talk, Mydeimos.”

“We did.”

“It must have been a difficult conversation to last three whole days.”

“It was hard at some points, yes.”

A muffled snicker, quickly stopped by a hushed, “Ow, Dan Heng, I didn't say anything!”

“… I mean there was much to discuss.”

“I have no doubt.”

Quiet.

Then, “Little Prince, you must've done a number on the Deliverer boy this time, eh? It's gotta be real serious for Prof Nax to get this worked up.”

“Cifera!”

“Oh it's fine Princess Homebody, someone has to say the truth. Otherwise what are we waiting here for?”

“Whatever it is, I'm sure Phainon will pull through—”

They all jump when the door swings open.

“Mydei,” Hyacine says, tone level. “You can see him now.”

Mydei is in the room before she finishes speaking.

“What's wrong?” he asks. It has been so long since he felt true fear that he almost doesn't recognize it, churning in his gut and rising to the back of his throat. “Is he sick?”

Phainon's tired voice floats from the kline. “*He* is right here, waiting for his husband to come sit beside him already.”

Tension drains out of his shoulders. He sighs and takes a seat. “If you've found the strength to jest, then perhaps this isn't such a serious ailment after all.”

Some of Phainon’s color has returned, and his eyes are luminous and clear. There's an odd restrained quality to his expression, like he's holding something back.

Across the kline on Phainon's other side, Mydei notices Sunday and Hyacine glancing at each other. He becomes aware of the stillness in the room, a breath held in anticipation.

“What?” he says, taking Phainon's hand. It's warm to the touch, the pulse strong.

Phainon entwines their fingers and, ever so gently, brings them to his lower belly.

Mydei’s *thymós* lifts its head, called to attention by a deep, primal instinct. He looks from their hands back to Phainon, mouth suddenly dry.

“Hyacine, Sunday, if you would?” Phainon says.

Hyacine bobs her head so fast it looks like it hurts, each bounce sending a burst of rainbow sparkles into the air. Sunday’s wings flutter before they cover his mouth, hiding the hint of a smile.

They extend a hand over Phainon’s and Mydei’s.

“The future will be bright,” Hyacine says like a promise, an invocation, “for we who fly into twilight.” Radiant light spills from her palm onto their hands. It is warm and soft, like being enveloped by sunset clouds.

Sunday's pitch drops into something almost otherworldly, pristine and elegant, as he intones, “Haven in palm, grant thy exalted sweep." His halo and irises glow. “*Resonance*.”

An indescribable sound like faint music fills the room. Under Mydei’s hand, where Phainon has it splayed out, he feels it.

The stirring of creation. Small, near miniscule. But there. Real.

His knees hit the floor as he abandons the seat to come closer. “Phainon.”

Phainon says, with devastating warmth, “It looks like we’re getting both of our wishes. What say you to that, Mydei?”

Mydei kisses him.

Sweet and deep and slow. The kind of kiss Mydei usually reserves for the privacy of their rooms. It might have gone on for hours, if not for Sunday and Hyacine both clearing their throats pointedly.

Mydei pulls away from his gasping husband with great reluctance. “How? It’s only been three days.”

Hyacine does not ask him to elaborate. “Actually, the energy signature that Mr. Sunday and I found is several weeks old. Almost a month. There are a few layers around it that feel very new, perhaps formed within the last few days.”

“New layers? Could it be more than one?” Phainon asks, having caught his breath.

Mydei’s head goes slightly fuzzy. *Strife and calamity*. If they say yes, he might actually faint. The detachment’s celebration would make Okhema shake for days.

Sunday shuffles his feet, a rare break in his composure. “If I may use an analogy, it may be that the—ahem—seed was planted some time ago, but waited for the right conditions to grow. Like a bird waiting for a safe nest before laying its egg.”

Hyacine says, without a hint of shame, “My working hypothesis is that the inordinate amount of sex you two had gave it a push to grow as an act of self-preservation.”

Well then.

Phainon gives Mydei a bemused look. “We should have done that sooner if that’s all it took for me to get pregnant,” he laughs. Happiness is beautiful on him.

Mydei is about to kiss him breathless again when the door crashes open. Its hinges and locking mechanism crumple to the side like paper, and the famed Chrysos Heirs and esteemed Nameless fall over the threshold in a mess of flailing limbs.

“Oh my *gods*,” Stelle wails from the bottom of the pile, “I knew it! I fucking knew it, I’m so happy for you guys, I need to call the others, Caelus you better pay up or I’ll—”

“Be quiet, Stelle!” scolds Caelus with shiny tears in his eyes. “Don’t you realize they were having a moment—” he dissolves into happy sobs.

“We will pay for the door,” Dan Heng as Caelus weeps into his shoulder. “Congratulations, you two.”

“Snowy!” Tribios chirps and claps her hands, perfectly happy to be squished in the middle of the pile. “We’re all so happy for you and De!”

“Doot doot,” Little Ica agrees magnanimously at the top of the pyramid.

The pile shakes as Anaxa’s voice thunders from somewhere, muffled and unintelligible.

Cipher cackles. “Prof, you know my powers can’t do *that* anymore. And isn’t this what you and the Goldweaver have been waiting for?”

Castorice, dear Castorice, catches Mydei’s eye with a brilliant, jubilant smile. *I told you*, she mouths, then mimes a puppy walking. *Chimeras*. *Same*.

Of course Beagle Coconut is also pregnant. Honey Fruitcake is going to be insufferable. Mydei accepts it and dips his head, knowing they’ll speak more later.

The pile is pulled apart by no small amount of effort, and everyone falls into place around them. A golden thread opens the window. The place swells with sunlight and a gentle breeze, followed by tears and laughter and the baffling exchange of Balance Coins.

Mydei rests his head on Phainon’s chest, one hand covering his lower belly. They bask in the middle of their family and friends, and greet more who come into the room. At some point, Aglaea takes Anaxa’s seat closer to the kline.

“Did you know from the start?” asks Phainon.

“Nothing was impossible anymore,” Aglaea replies indulgently. “If you and Mydei wanted it, I knew you would find a way.”

Her relaxed features turn solemn. Quietly, she says, “There are already ripples beyond our reach. Everything is going to change.”

The stakes have been raised. They will have to call a formal meeting. Potential threats must be assessed, defenses shored up and allies gathered. The Cosmos waits for no one to be ready.

When Mydei looks at his husband, he sees the same unwavering resolve in Phainon’s eyes that burns inside Mydei like the sun.

“Not everything,” Mydei says. “Not this.”

Under the protective cradle of their hands, their child grows.

When they are alone, Mydei slides into the kline and into his husband's arms.

Phainon says, "I want to raise them in Aedes Elysiae. At least for a few years. Then I want them to see Castrum Kremnos once the rebuilding is done, especially the library. The world we've made—I want them to have the chance to explore it. To fall in love with it, and not be afraid of it."

Countless cycles unfold from the crest of his voice. The love and the longing, the grief and the victorious triumph.

"They will have it," Mydei promises. "That and more."

Phainon murmurs, "Cyrene sent word. The fields are growing back. She says the rivers are starting to flow again. We'll have to build a new house closer to the village square." He smiles. "I hope you're ready, Mydei."

"I look forward to it," Mydei says. "A family with you. A lifetime of it."

To wish, despite everything—it is a feeling Mydei has long known. It now settles at long last, glowing gold like the promise of tomorrow.

Mydei holds Phainon and finally rests.

... were the Sky Father to will it, creation would answer. However, to employ the word 'creation' ultimately leaves its most honest meaning up to numerous interpretations. Take, for example, the School of the Caprists in the Grove of Epiphany, who enshrine all living things —beasts and bugs alike—with the title of 'creation'.

Contrast this with the opinions of the Nodists, for whom 'creation' is carried forth in the computations of numbers and its derivatives. For the Cryptogenists, now called the Nousporists, those few who dare to push beyond the limits of academic study, 'creation' is a reflection of that mysterious composition they call a 'soul'.

Few words can describe the difficulties, then, in reconciling these schools of thought to prove —or disprove—that which remains one of Kephale's most mysterious divine attributes.

Thus and henceforth, there still remains much to be discussed and much to be seen regarding worldbearing and other matters of divinity.

- an excerpt from *'A Retrospective Review on the Titans of Creation, Volume I: Kephale'*

Chapter End Notes

This fic was conceptualized before 3.4 was released, and in just a few weeks we'll be reaching the end of the Amphoreus storyline. How time flies! After being away from fanfic writing for years and seeing how the fandom scene looked, I was hesitant about sharing this story. However, the feedback I've received from everyone has been so lovely and encouraging. Thank you all so much!

I especially want to thank Hoshi, Dan, Honey, and Arial, as well as those in the myph server, for your continued support <3

Did everyone catch the in-game references, subplots, sub-ships, and little bits of worldbuilding I sprinkled in this chapter and fic? If so, let me know what you found!

Once again, thank you for sticking with me and giving this story a chance. I loved writing this fic (it's my babyy) and I'm so happy you showed it just as much love.

(Fun fact: the first and most favorite line I wrote for this fic is in this chapter! Can you tell which one it is?)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!